OpenExplainer User Guide

OpenExplainer

0.1.0

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CHAPTER 1

Welcome to OpenExplainer

In This Chapter

- What OpenExplainer is for
- What you need
- How this guide is organized

This guide shows you how to use OpenExplainer 0.1.0 to make how-to books and tutorials from pictures of your screen. It was made with OpenExplainer itself: every page, every picture and every export you can read here came out of the program it describes.

Start with Chapter 2 if you want to be making something in ten minutes. Come back to the other chapters when you need them.

1.1 What OpenExplainer is for

OpenExplainer helps you explain how to use a computer program. You take pictures of the program as you use it, say what each picture shows in plain words, and OpenExplainer lays everything out as a book. You can print the book, send it as a PDF or Word file, or put it on the web as a help site.

It makes **still pictures only**. There is no video recording. A tutorial made of pictures and short numbered steps is quick to scan, easy to search, simple to keep up to date, and a screen reader can read it aloud, which a video cannot do.

What you can make

The main output is a **book for paper**: chapters, numbered steps, pictures with lettered callouts, boxed notes, a contents list and an index. It comes out as a PDF made for printing, or as a Word file with real styles.

The same book can also become a **help site** (a folder of web pages with search), a **Markdown** copy, or a **JSON** copy that holds the pictures too and can be brought back into OpenExplainer. You can also cut a **short step-by-step guide** out of the book: one task, a few pictures, one or two pages.

Free, and it works by hand

OpenExplainer is free and open source under the Apache 2.0 licence. Everything in it works by hand. The AI help in Chapter 8 is optional, runs on your own PC if you turn it on, and never puts anything in your book until you say yes.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
> You do not have to be a writer or a programmer. If you can use the program you want to explain, and you can say in a sentence what a button does, you can make a good book.

1.2 What you need

OpenExplainer needs very little.

Your PC

A PC with **Windows 11** and a 64-bit Intel or AMD processor. Other versions of Windows, and Windows on ARM, have not been tested yet.

About 60 MB of free disk space for the program. If you use the built-in AI model, add about 2.7 GB for the model file.

What you do not need

You do not need an account, a sign-in or an internet connection to use the program. The internet is used only when you choose to download the AI model. You do not need a mouse: everything can be done from the keyboard, and the program works with a screen reader.

You do need the program you want to explain, installed and working, so that you can take pictures of it.

1.3 How this guide is organized

The guide follows the order in which you work.

Chapter 2, Getting started, installs the program, tours the window and makes your first project. **Chapter 3, Building your book,** is about chapters, topics and writing a page. **Chapter 4, Taking pictures,** covers capturing a window, a rectangle of the screen, and click-by-click capture. **Chapter 5, Explaining your pictures,** is about descriptions, lettered callouts and drawing marks.

Chapter 6, Checking your work, describes the book check. **Chapter 7, Making your outputs,** covers the print preview, PDF, Word, the help site, Markdown, JSON, short guides and the index. **Chapter 8** is about the optional AI help, and **Chapter 9** about letting an AI assistant use OpenExplainer while you are away. **Chapter 10** is a reference: the keyboard, where your files are kept, what to do when something goes wrong, and a glossary.

How the pages are written

Names of buttons, menus and boxes appear in bold, exactly as they appear on screen, for example **Save as**. Steps you follow are numbered. When a step has a picture, the picture shows the program just before you do the step.

Boxed notes stand out from the text. A **Caution** warns you about something that can lose your work or surprise you. A **Design Tip**, **Power Tip**, **Time Saver** and **Bright Idea** pass on advice. **New** marks something that is new in this version.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> A Caution is the one kind of box you should never skip. Read it before you go on.

CHAPTER 2

Getting started

In This Chapter

- Installing OpenExplainer
- A tour of the window
- Making your first project
- Saving and opening a project

In this chapter you install OpenExplainer, take a short tour of its window and make your first project. It takes about ten minutes, and it is the only chapter you need before you can start work.

2.1 Installing OpenExplainer

OpenExplainer comes as one setup file with a name like **OpenExplainer_0.1.0_x64-setup.exe**. It installs for you alone, so Windows does not ask for an administrator's password.

1. Double-click the setup file.

   Result: Windows may show a blue screen that says Windows protected your PC. It appears for any program from a publisher that Windows does not know yet. Click More info, and then click Run anyway.

2. Wait while the setup copies the program.

   Result: It takes a few seconds. When it finishes, the program is in your own AppData folder, and an OpenExplainer icon is in the Start menu and on the desktop.

3. Open OpenExplainer from the Start menu or from the desktop icon.

   Result: The OpenExplainer window opens with an empty project.

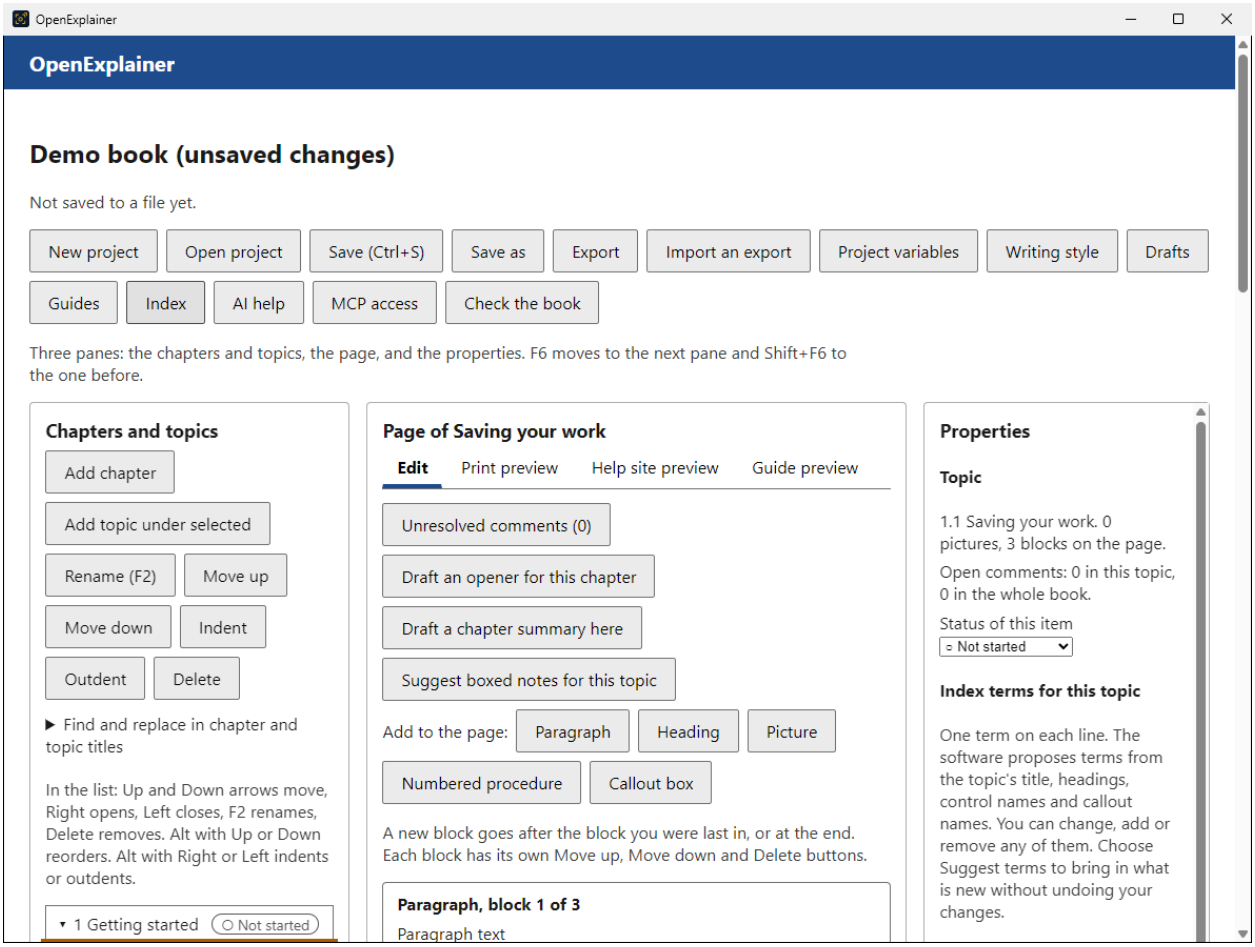
> **⚠ CAUTION**
> The first versions of OpenExplainer are not signed yet, which is why Windows asks you to confirm. Run only a setup file that you got from a place you trust.

Updating and removing

To update, run the newer setup file. It replaces the program and leaves your projects alone, because your projects are files that you keep wherever you chose to save them.

To remove OpenExplainer, open Windows Settings, choose Apps, then Installed apps, find OpenExplainer and choose Uninstall. If the uninstaller offers to delete the program's data, leave that unticked unless you want to remove the downloaded AI model as well, which is about 2.7 GB.

2.2 A tour of the window



This is the whole of the OpenExplainer window. Across the top is a row of buttons for the things you do to the whole project: start a new one, open one, save it, make an export and so on. Under the row, the **project's name** appears as a large heading. It says *unsaved changes* beside the name whenever there is something that has not been saved.

The three panes

Below the buttons are three panes side by side. You can move between them from the keyboard with F6, and back with Shift+F6.

Chapters and topics is on the left. It lists your book as a tree: chapters, and the topics inside them. The buttons above the list add, rename, move, indent and delete. A topic is one subject that gets its own page, such as Saving your work.

Page is in the middle. It shows the page of the topic you chose. Its tabs switch between **Edit**, **Print preview**, **Help site preview** and **Guide preview**, so you can see your book as it will look when it is finished. In Edit you add the things a page is made of: paragraphs, headings, pictures, numbered procedures and boxed notes. Under the page is the list of the topic's pictures, with the buttons that capture or import more.

Properties is on the right. It tells you about what you have chosen: the topic's status, its index terms, and the block you are working in.

The buttons across the top

New project, **Open project**, **Save**, **Save as**: the usual ones. **Export** makes the PDF, Word file, help site and the others. **Import an export** brings back a book you exported as JSON. **Project variables** holds values such as the product name that can be used everywhere. **Writing style** and **Drafts** belong to the optional AI help. **Guides** makes short step-by-step guides. **Index** shows the book's index. **AI help** and **MCP access** switch on the optional AI features. **Check the book** looks for things worth fixing before you share the book.

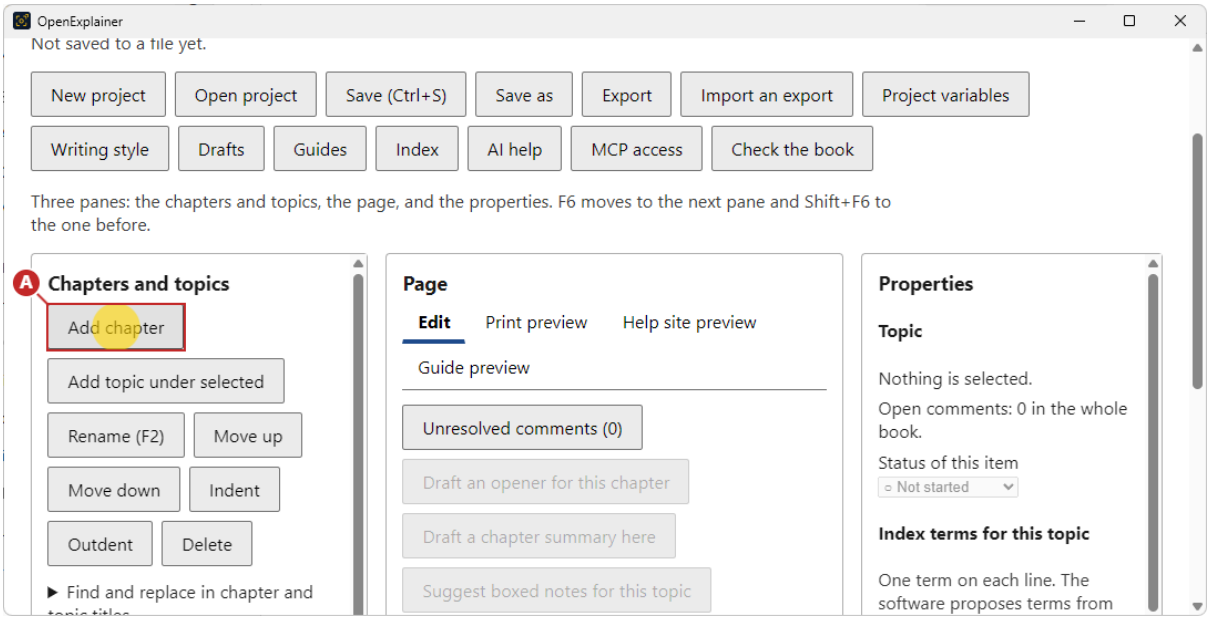
> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> You do not have to learn all of these now. The three panes and the Save button are enough to start. The rest are explained when you need them, in the chapters that follow.

2.3 Making your first project

A OpenExplainer project is a book. It has chapters, and each chapter has topics. In this exercise you make one chapter with one topic and type a sentence on its page. You will use the same few buttons every time you make a book.

To start a book, click **New project**, type its name, and choose what to start from in the list called *Start from*: **Software user guide** (a few chapters already made: overview, installation, using and troubleshooting), **OpenStage how-to book** (a few starter chapters), or **Empty project**. Then click **Create**. This exercise starts from an empty project.

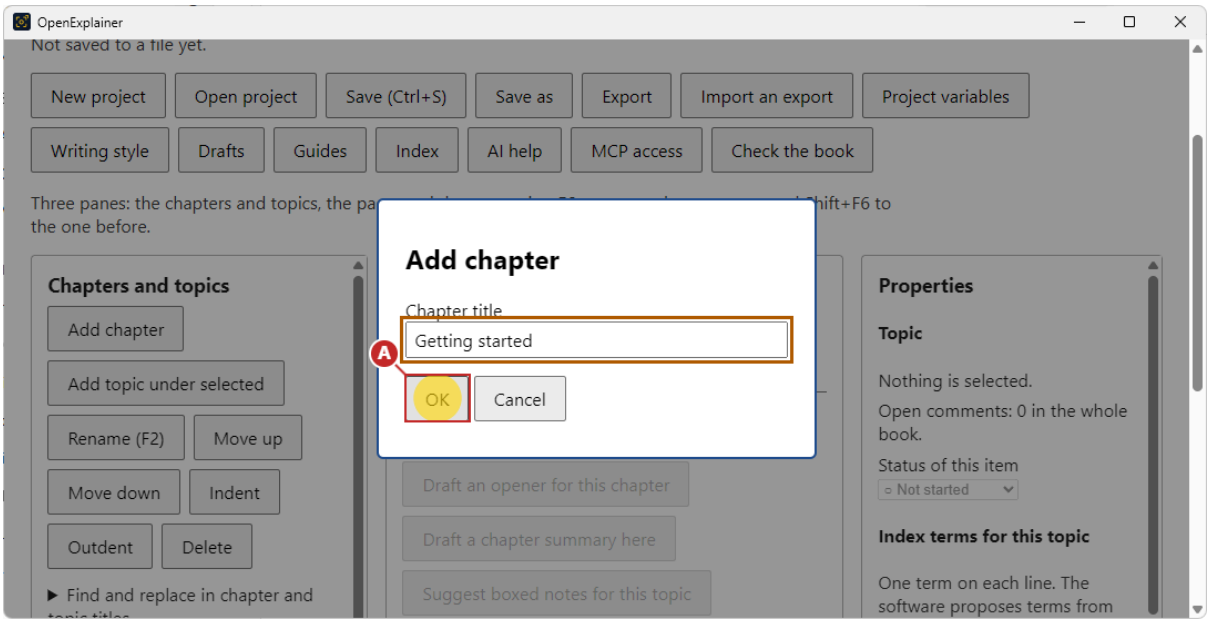
1. Click **Add chapter**.



A. Add chapter: Starts a new chapter.

Result: A small window asks for the chapter's title.

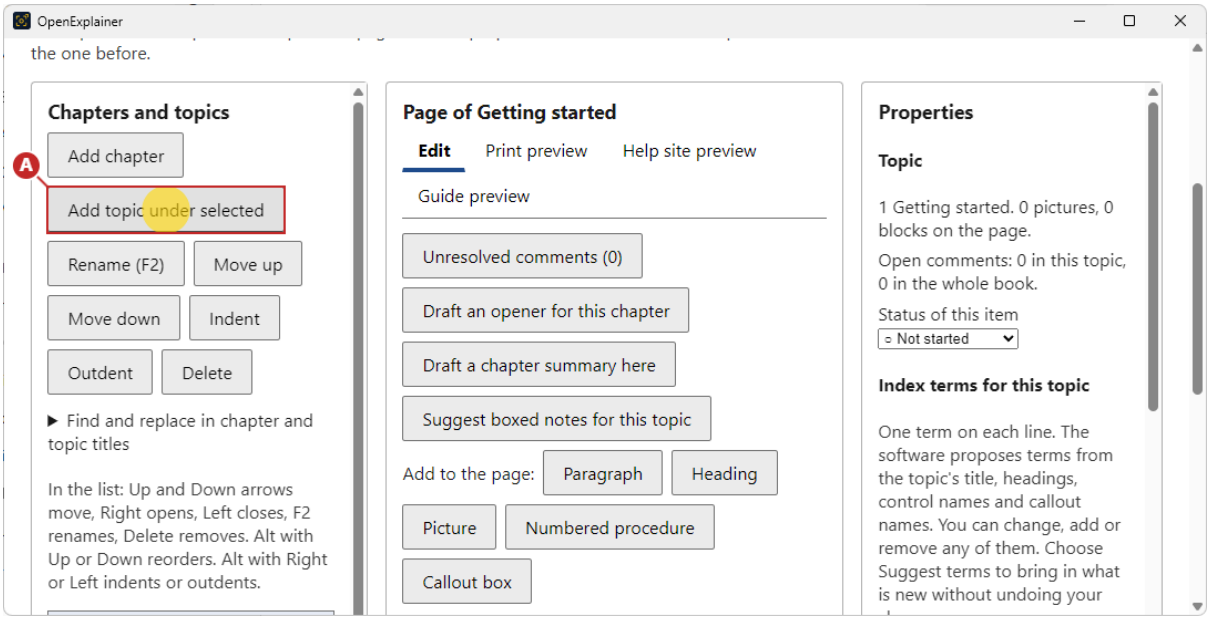
2. Type a title, such as Getting started, and click **OK**.



A. OK: Makes the chapter with the title you typed.

Result: The chapter appears in the list on the left.

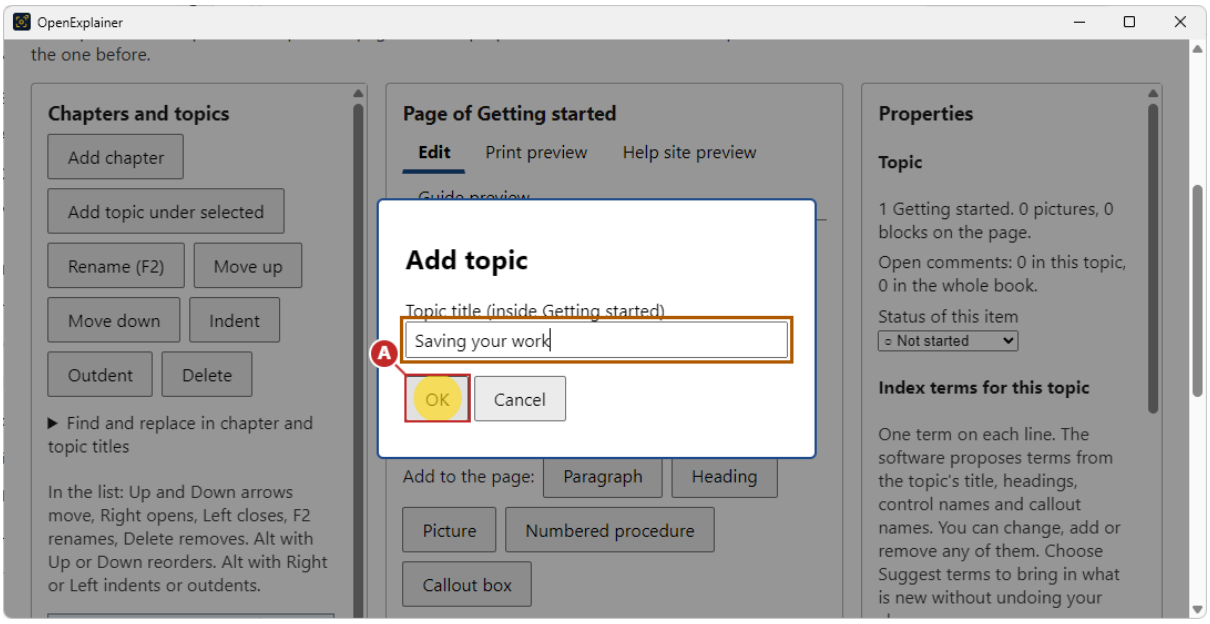
3. Click **Add topic under selected**.



A. Add topic under selected: Starts a new topic inside the chapter that is selected.

Result: Another small window asks for the topic's title.

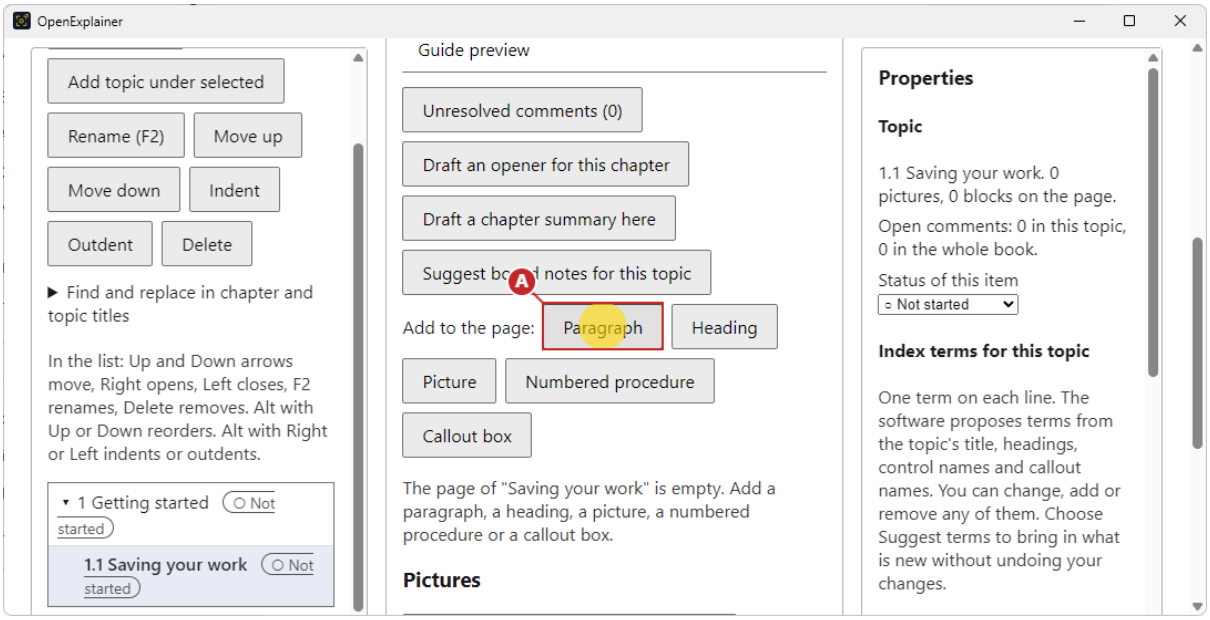
4. Type a title, such as Saving your work, and click **OK**.



A. OK: Makes the topic with the title you typed.

Result: The topic appears under the chapter, and its page is empty.

5. Click **Paragraph**.



A. Paragraph: Adds a box for a paragraph to the page.

Result: A box for a paragraph appears on the page, ready for you to type in.

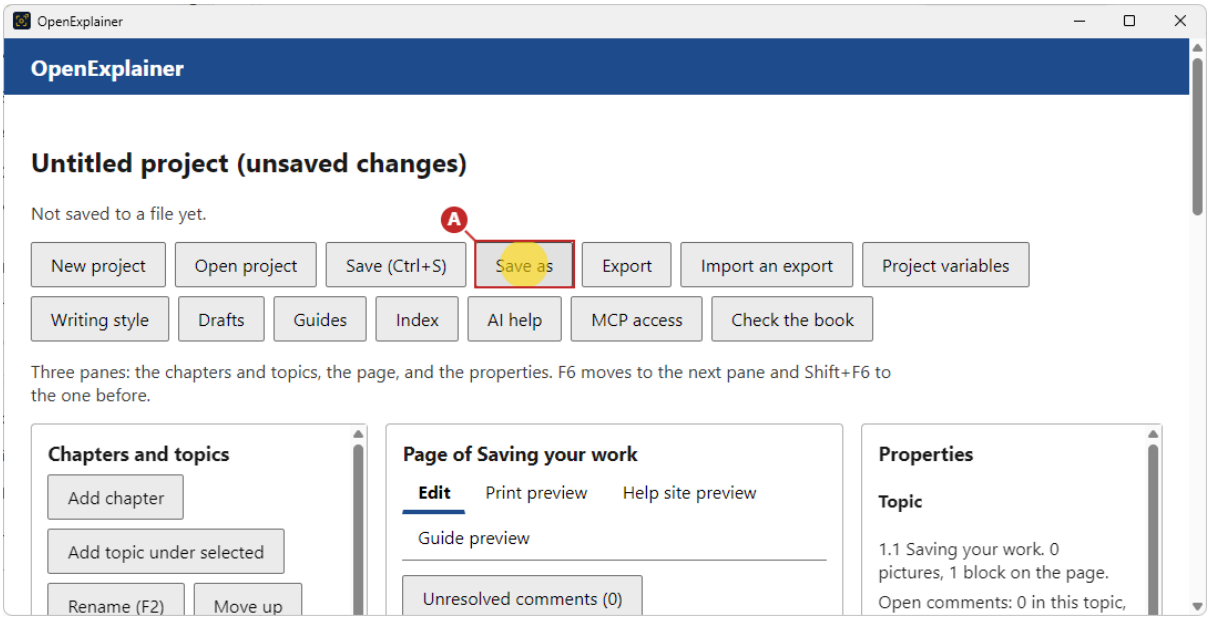
Now type a sentence in the box. Under the box, a preview shows how the sentence will look in the book. Words you put between double square brackets, such as **Save**, are the **names of buttons and menus**. They are shown in bold in the book. Chapter 3 explains this in full.

> **TIME SAVER**
> You can also use the keyboard for every one of these steps. Press Tab to move from button to button, and Enter to press the one you are on.

2.4 Saving and opening a project

A project is saved as **one file** that holds all the text, the pictures and the settings, so you can copy it, e-mail it or keep it on a USB drive. The file's name ends in **.openexplainer**.

1. Click **Save as**.



A. Save as: Opens Windows' Save dialog, where you name the project and choose where to keep it.

   Result: Windows shows its own Save dialog.

2. Choose a folder, type a name for the project and click Save in the dialog.

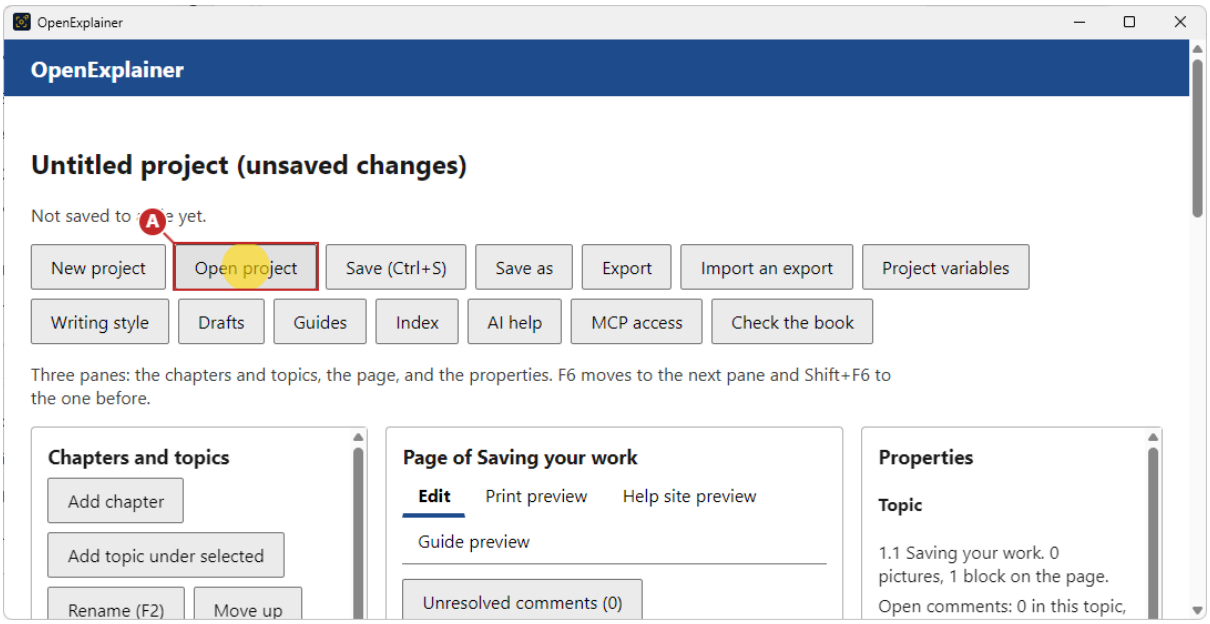
   Result: The project is saved. The words *unsaved changes* disappear from the heading, and the line under the heading shows where the file is.

After that, **Save** keeps your work up to date without asking anything. You can also press Ctrl+S.

The title of the program's window, in the title bar, on the taskbar and in the list you get with Alt+Tab, is the name of the project. It says *(unsaved changes)* in words when there are changes that are not saved, the same as the heading on the page, so a screen reader can tell you which project is open.

Opening a project again

1. Click **Open project**.



A. Open project: Opens Windows' Open dialog, where you choose a saved project.

   Result: Windows shows its own Open dialog. If you have changes that are not saved, OpenExplainer first asks whether you want to continue without saving them.

2. Choose the file you saved and click Open in the dialog.

   Result: Your book appears, with every chapter, topic and picture as you left it.

Opening a project from Windows

You can also open a project without starting OpenExplainer first: in File Explorer, double-click the project's file, or right-click it and choose **Open with**. OpenExplainer starts with that project open. The installer sets this up for you, and only for you, so it needs no administrator rights. If OpenExplainer is already open, the project opens in a second copy of the program, and what you were working on in the first copy is not touched.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
>
> OpenExplainer does not save by itself. Save before you close the program or start a new project, or the changes since your last save are lost.

CHAPTER 3

Building your book

In This Chapter

- Chapters and topics
- Writing a topic's page
- Numbered steps
- Boxed notes
- Bold, italic and control names
- Variables
- Comments and status

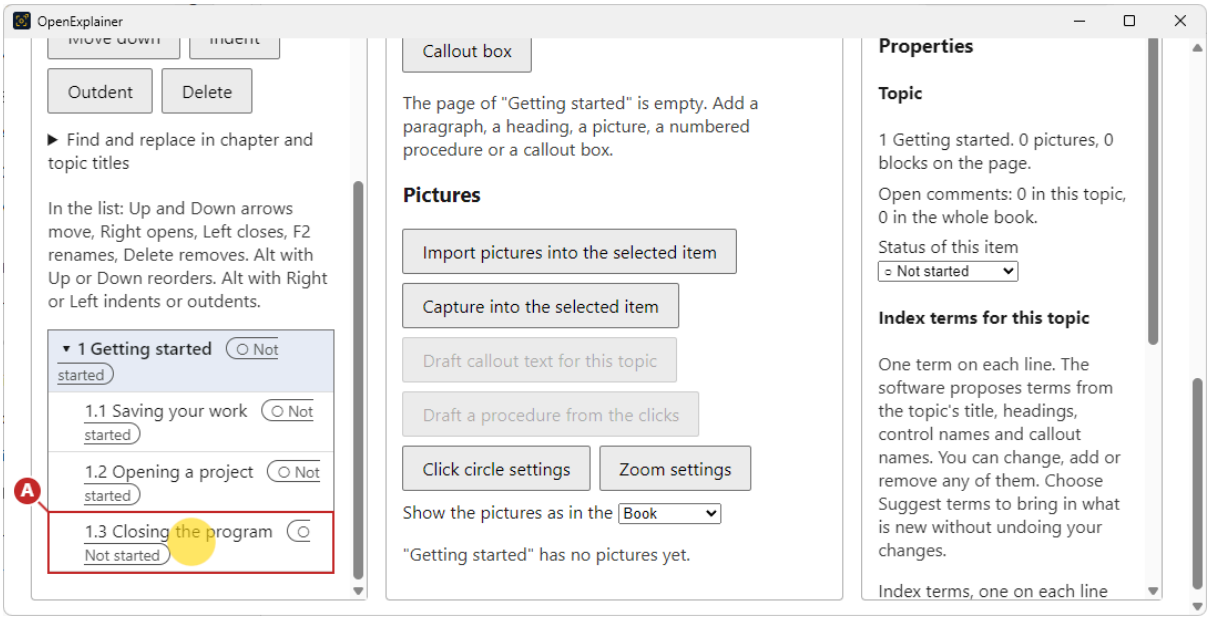
This chapter is about the writing side of OpenExplainer: how a book is arranged, and the blocks you use to write a page. Pictures come in Chapter 4. If you made the practice project in Chapter 2, you already know most of the buttons.

3.1 Chapters and topics

A book is a **tree**. The top level holds **chapters**. Inside a chapter are **topics**, and a topic can hold more topics. Every one of them has a page of its own, a status and a place in the list on the left.

You never type numbers. OpenExplainer numbers the list for you (1, 1.1, 1.1.1 and so on) and numbers it again whenever you move something, so the numbers in your book are always right.

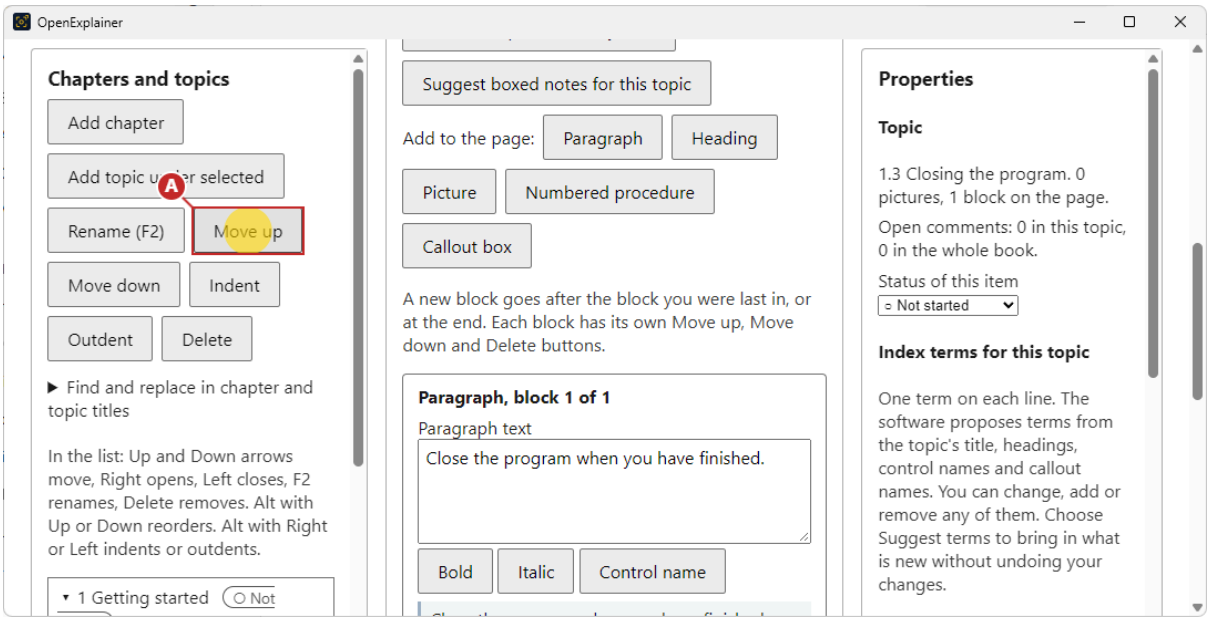
1. Click a topic in the list on the left.



A. Closing the program: A topic in the list of chapters and topics.

Result: Its page appears in the middle, and its details appear on the right.

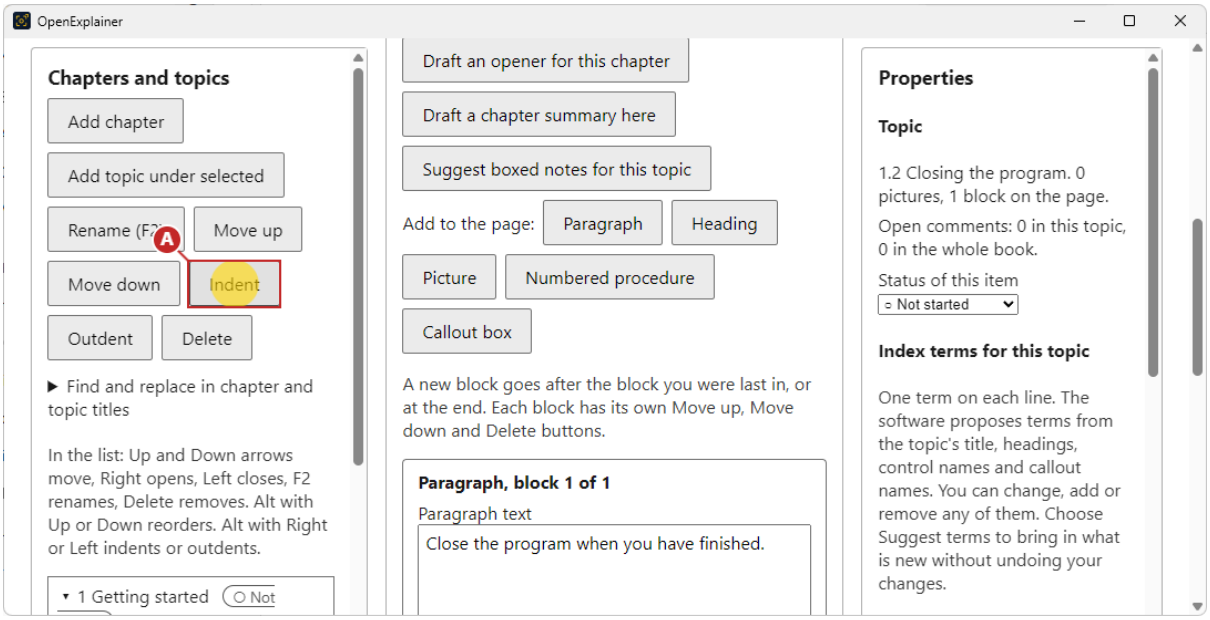
2. Click **Move up** to move it above the topic before it. **Move down** moves it below the next one.



A. Move up: Moves the selected item above the one before it.

Result: The list and the numbers change to match.

3. Click **Indent** to put the topic inside the item above it. **Outdent** brings it back out.



A. Indent: Puts the selected topic inside the item above it.

Result: The topic becomes a sub-topic, and its number gets another part.

The other buttons

Add chapter and **Add topic under selected** make new items at the end. **Rename** (or F2) changes a title. **Delete** removes the selected item and everything inside it, and asks you first. Under the buttons, **Find and replace in chapter and topic titles** opens a small form for changing a word in every title at once.

Working from the keyboard

In the list, Up and Down move between items. Right opens a chapter, and Left closes it. F2 renames. Delete removes. Alt with Up or Down reorders, and Alt with Right or Left indents or outdents.

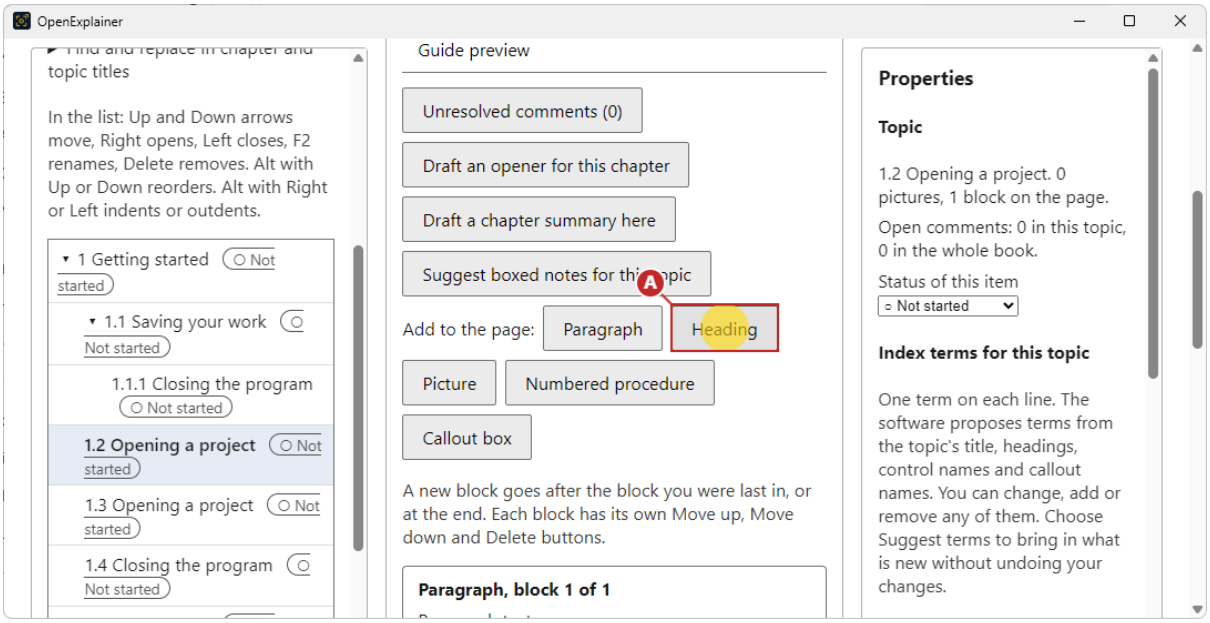
> **⚠ CAUTION**
> Deleting a chapter or topic deletes every page and picture inside it. Look at what the confirmation says before you agree.

3.2 Writing a topic's page

A page is a stack of **blocks**. There are five kinds: a **paragraph**, a **heading**, a **picture**, a **numbered procedure** and a **callout box**. You add them one at a time with the buttons under *Add to the page*.

OpenExplainer is not a free-flowing word processor. Each block is its own labelled box. That makes the page easy to move around by keyboard, and it lets a screen reader say exactly which block you are in.

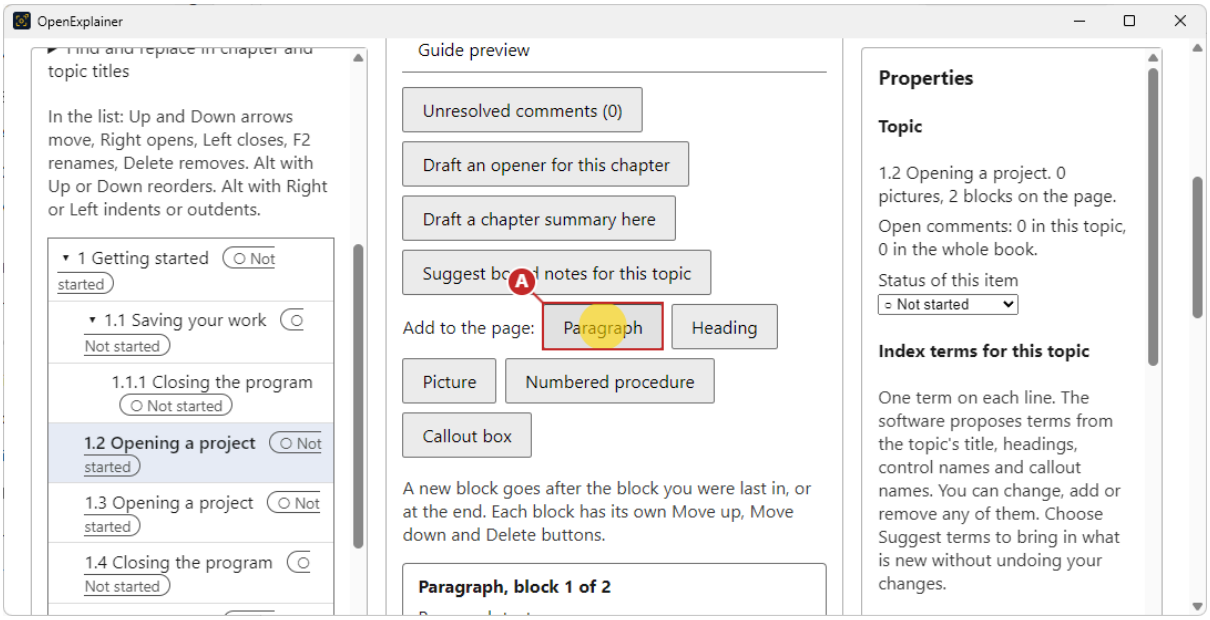
1. Click **Heading**.



A. Heading: Adds a heading to the page.

Result: A heading box appears after the block you were last in, and the keyboard is already in it.

2. Type the heading, and then click **Paragraph**.



A. Paragraph: Adds a paragraph to the page.

Result: A paragraph box appears. Type your text in it.

A heading is plain text: the marks for bold, italic and control names are not read in a heading, and the box says so. A new block always goes **after the block you were last in**, or at the end of the page if you were in none. Every block has its own **Move up**, **Move down**, **Comments** and **Delete** buttons. A button that cannot be used, such as Move up on the first block, is switched off.

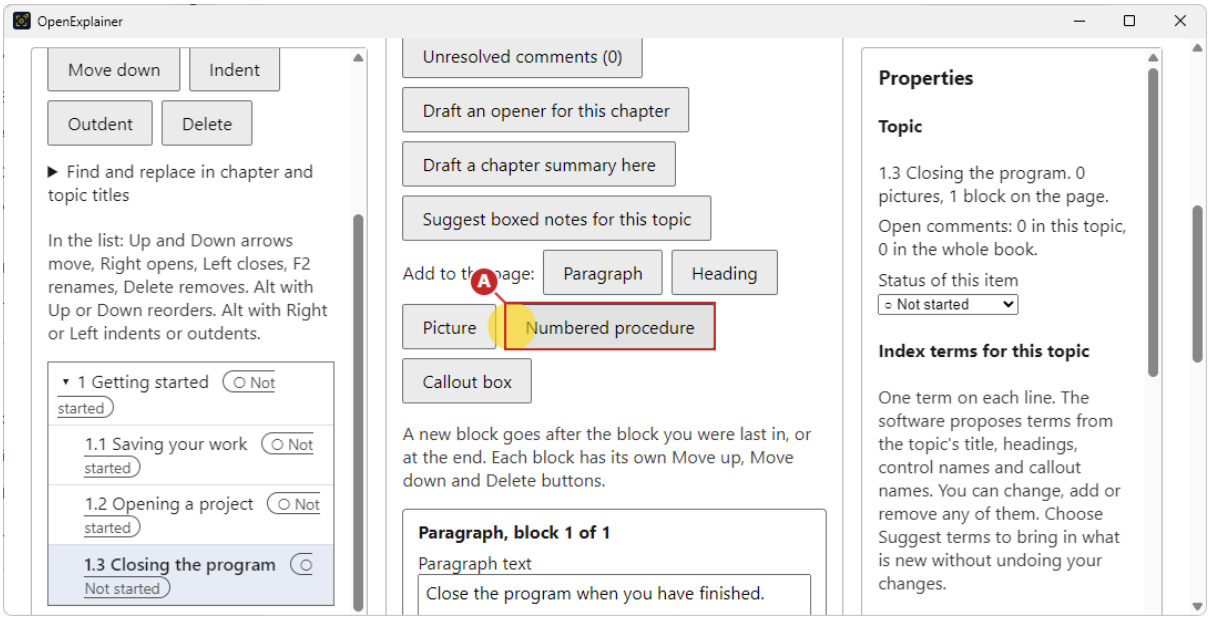
Under each text box is a **preview** that shows how your words will look in the book. The editor keeps the keyboard in the box while you type, and never redraws the page under your fingers.

> **TIME SAVER**
> You do not need to save after every block. The title of the project says *unsaved changes* until you do, and Ctrl+S saves.

3.3 Numbered steps

A **numbered procedure** is a list of steps. It is the part of a how-to book that readers use most, so it is worth writing well.

1. Click **Numbered procedure**.



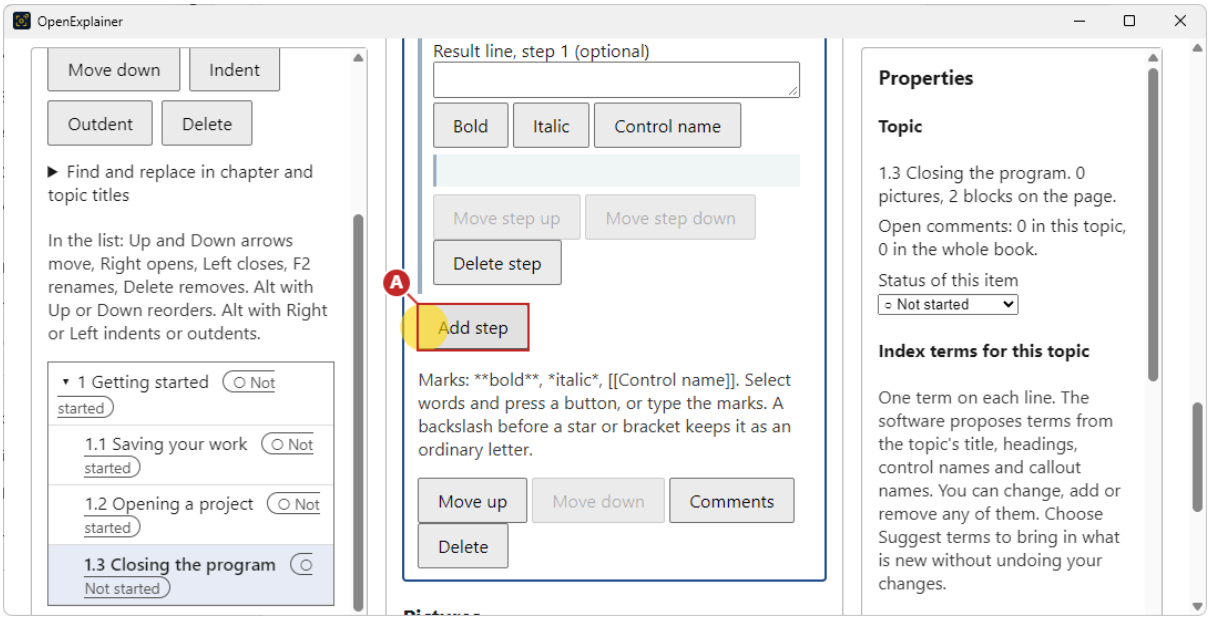
A. Numbered procedure: Adds a list of numbered steps to the page.

Result: A procedure with one empty step appears, and the keyboard is in its text box.

2. Type what the reader does, as a short sentence that starts with a verb.

Result: A line under the box shows how the step will look.

3. Click **Add step** for the next step.



A. Add step: Adds another step to the end of the procedure.

Result: Another step is added at the end, and the keyboard moves into it.

Each step has three parts. **What to do** is the sentence itself. A **picture for the step** is optional, and is chosen from the topic's pictures. A **result line** is optional and says what the reader should see afterwards, such as *The Save as window opens*. The numbers are never typed: they follow the order of the steps, and each procedure starts again at 1.

Writing good steps

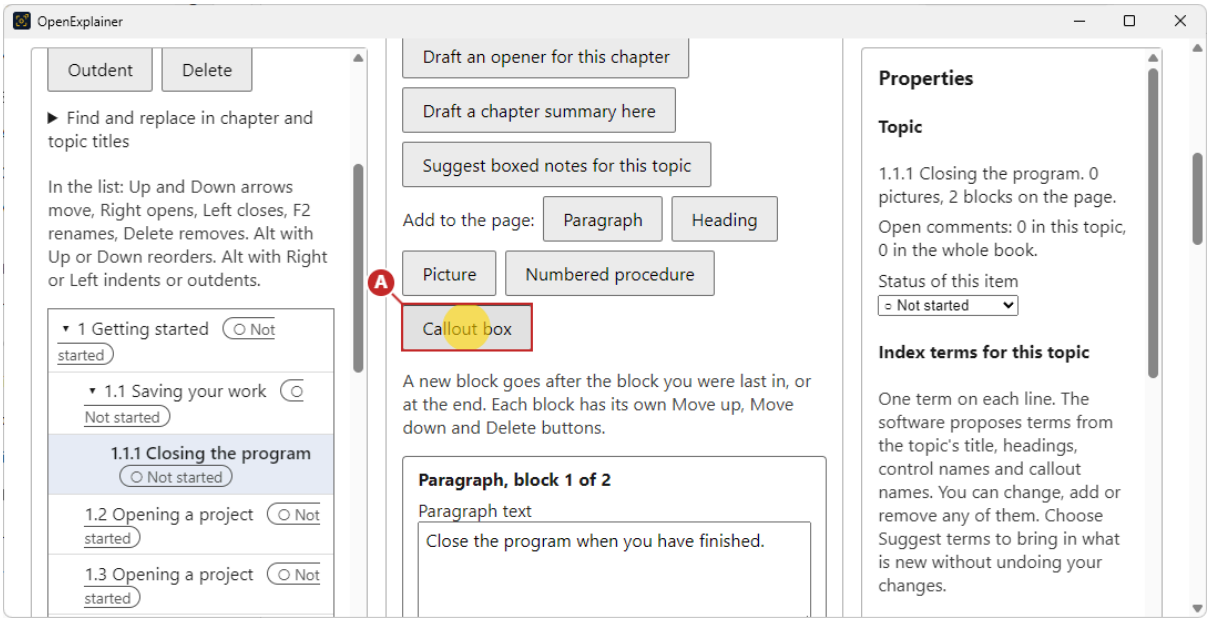
Start each step with a verb. Do one thing in each step. Name the control exactly as it appears on screen, and put its name between double square brackets so that it is shown in bold. Say **Click** for a button, **Choose** for a menu item, **Tick** for a check box and **Select** for a choice in a list.

> **POWER TIP**
>
> If you take your pictures click by click (Chapter 4), OpenExplainer can write the first version of the steps for you from what you clicked, with no AI. Press **Draft a procedure from the clicks** in the Pictures area.

3.4 Boxed notes

A **callout box** is a short note that stands out from the text. There are six kinds: **Design Tip**, **Caution**, **Bright Idea**, **Power Tip**, **Time Saver** and **New in this version**. Each kind says its name in words and has its own symbol, so you never have to rely on colour to tell them apart.

1. Click **Callout box**.



A. Callout box: Adds a boxed note to the page.

Result: A box appears with a menu called Kind of box and a text box.

2. Choose the kind of box, and type its text.

   Result: The preview under the box shows how it will look.

Using them well

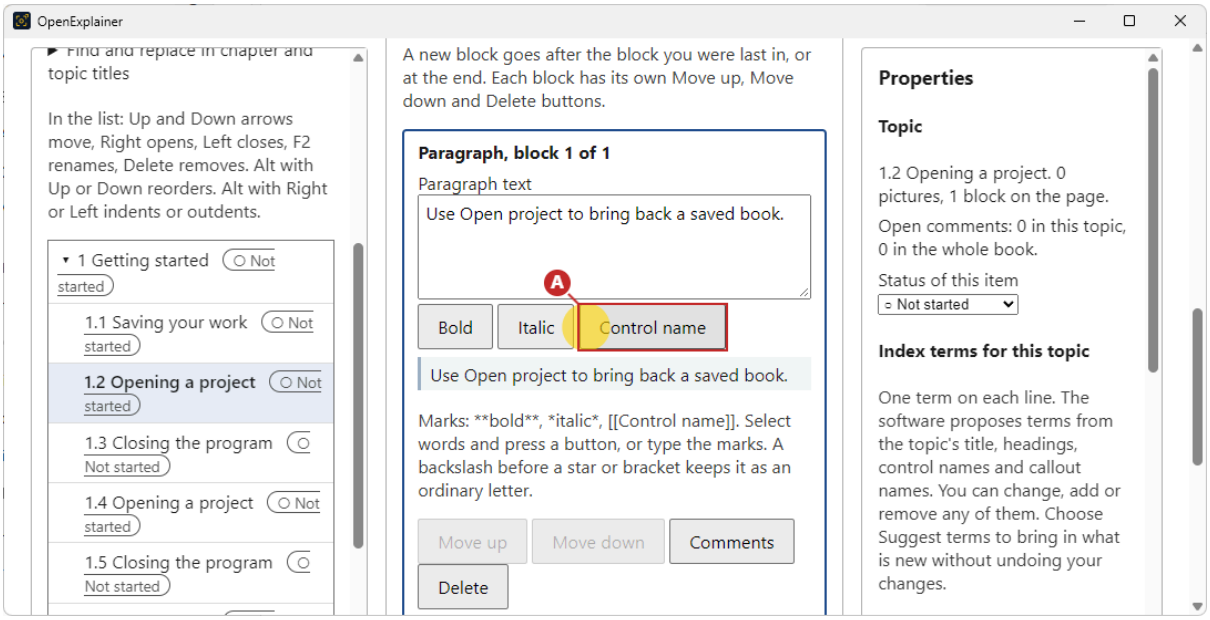
Use **Caution** only for something that could lose the reader's work or take them by surprise. Use a tip for advice that saves time. If every note is a Caution, readers stop reading them.

> ✎ **DESIGN TIP**
> Keep a box to one or two short sentences. If a note needs more room, it is really a paragraph.

3.5 Bold, italic and control names

Three small marks make words bold, italic or a **control name**. A control name is the label of a button, menu or box exactly as it appears on screen. In the book it is shown in bold, and OpenExplainer also uses it to build the index and to check your book (Chapter 6).

1. Select the words in the text box.
2. Click **Control name**. **Bold** and **Italic** work the same way.



A. Control name: Marks the selected words as the name of a button or menu, shown in bold in the book.

Result: The words are wrapped in marks, and the preview under the box shows them in bold.

You can also type the marks yourself. Put two stars on each side of bold words, one star on each side of italic words, and double square brackets around a control name. For example: **like this** for bold, *like this* for italic, and [[Save as]] for a control name. A backslash before a star

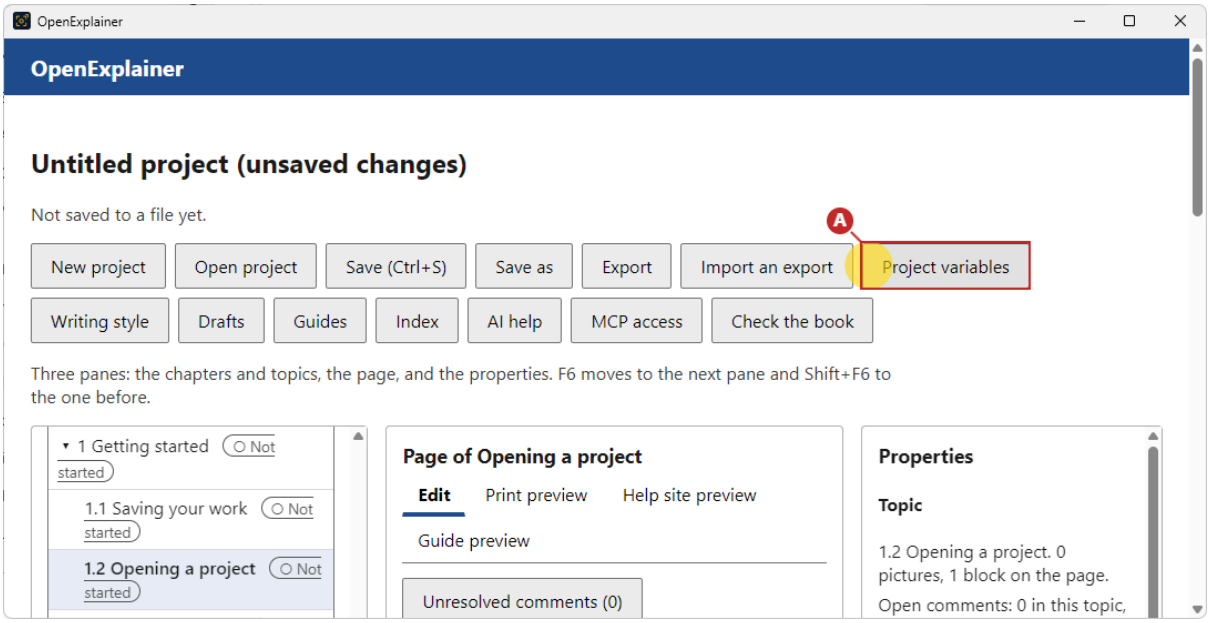
or a bracket, as in those examples, keeps it as an ordinary letter.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> If you press a mark button with no words selected, the editor tells you what to do instead of doing nothing.

3.6 Variables

A **variable** is a name that stands for a value that you use in many places, such as the name of the program you are explaining. You write the variable's name between double curly brackets, with no spaces, and OpenExplainer puts the value in when the book is made. When the product's name or version changes, you change it once.

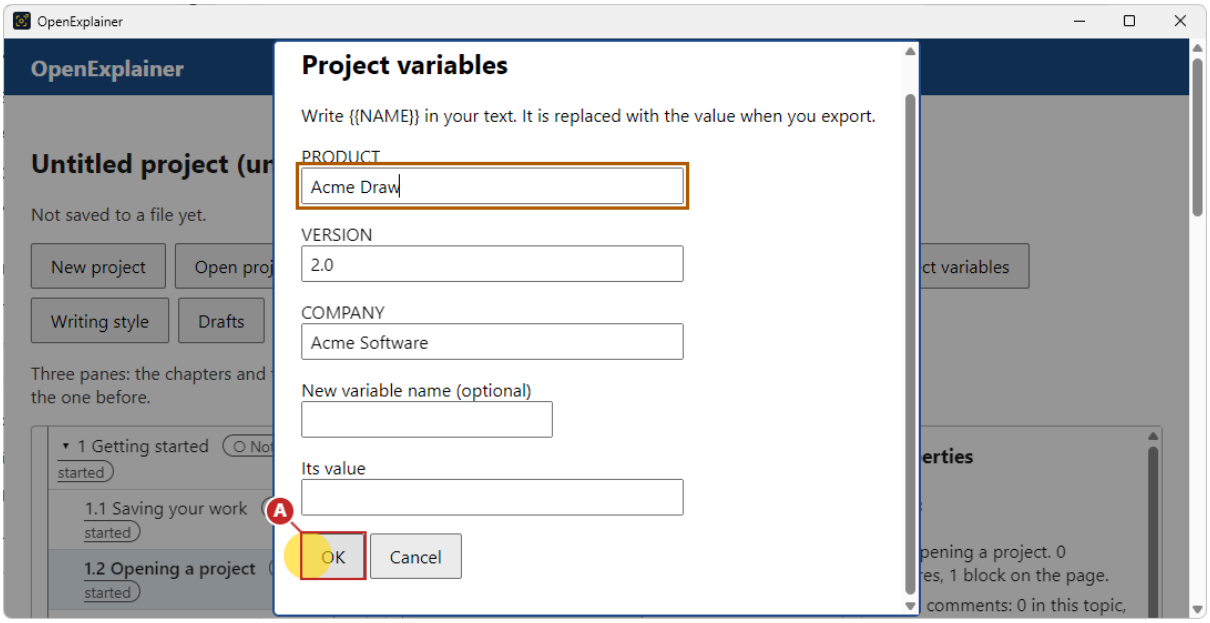
1. Click **Project variables**.



A. Project variables: Opens the list of values that can be used anywhere in the book.

Result: A window lists your variables with a box for each value.

2. Type a value in each box. To add another variable, type its name and its value at the bottom, and click **OK**.



A. OK: Keeps the variables and closes the window.

Result: The values are kept with the project.

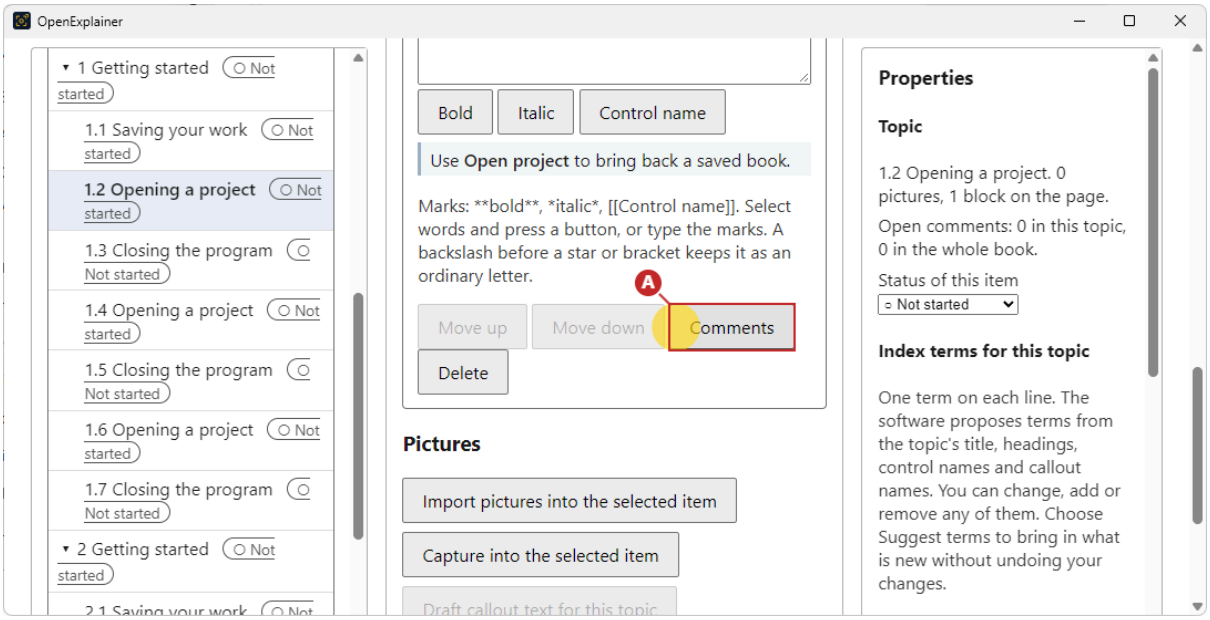
Three variables are special. **PRODUCT**, **VERSION** and **COMPANY** appear on the title page of the book. This guide uses them: its title page and many sentences come from the three values you can see in the window.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> A variable with no value is not hidden. Its bare name, still inside the curly brackets, would print in the book, and the book check tells you about it.

3.7 Comments and status

A **comment** is a working note about one block, for you or for a colleague. A comment is never put in the book, the PDF, the help site or any other output unless you ask for it in the JSON export.

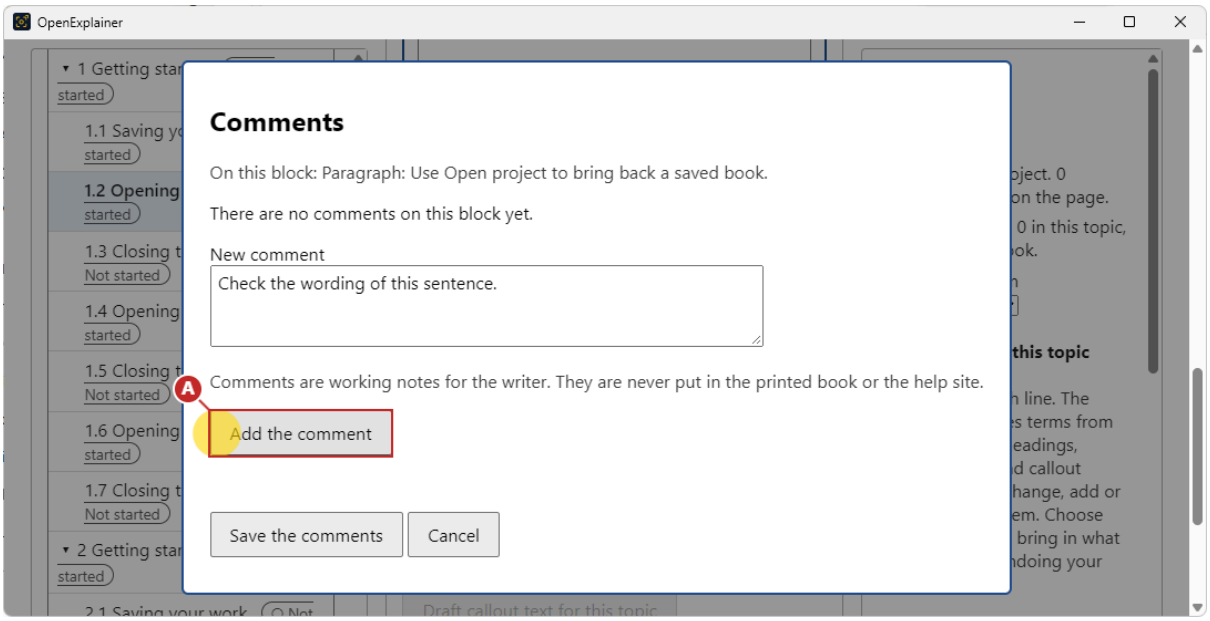
1. Click **Comments** on the block you want to write about.



A. Comments: Opens the working notes for this block.

Result: A window shows that block's comments, open ones first.

2. Type your note in the New comment box and click **Add the comment**. Then click **Save the comments**.



A. Add the comment: Adds the comment you typed to the block's list.

Result: The button on the block now says how many comments are open.

When the point is dealt with, open the window again and press **Resolve**. A resolved comment is shown as resolved in words, not by style alone. The button **Unresolved comments** at the top of the page lists every open comment in the book, and **Go to the block** takes you to each one.

Status

Every topic also has a **status**, which you choose on the right under *Status of this item*: ○ Not started, ◐ Captured, ✎ Drafted, ✓ Reviewed or ⚠ Needs recheck. Each status has a word and a symbol, never a colour alone. Use them to see at a glance what is finished.

CHAPTER 4

Taking pictures

In This Chapter

- Capturing a window
- Capturing a rectangle of the screen
- Capturing click by click
- Reviewing your clicks
- The click circle
- Importing pictures you already have

A how-to book is mostly pictures with words around them. OpenExplainer has three ways to take a picture of another program, and a way to bring in pictures you already have. This chapter explains each one and when to use it.

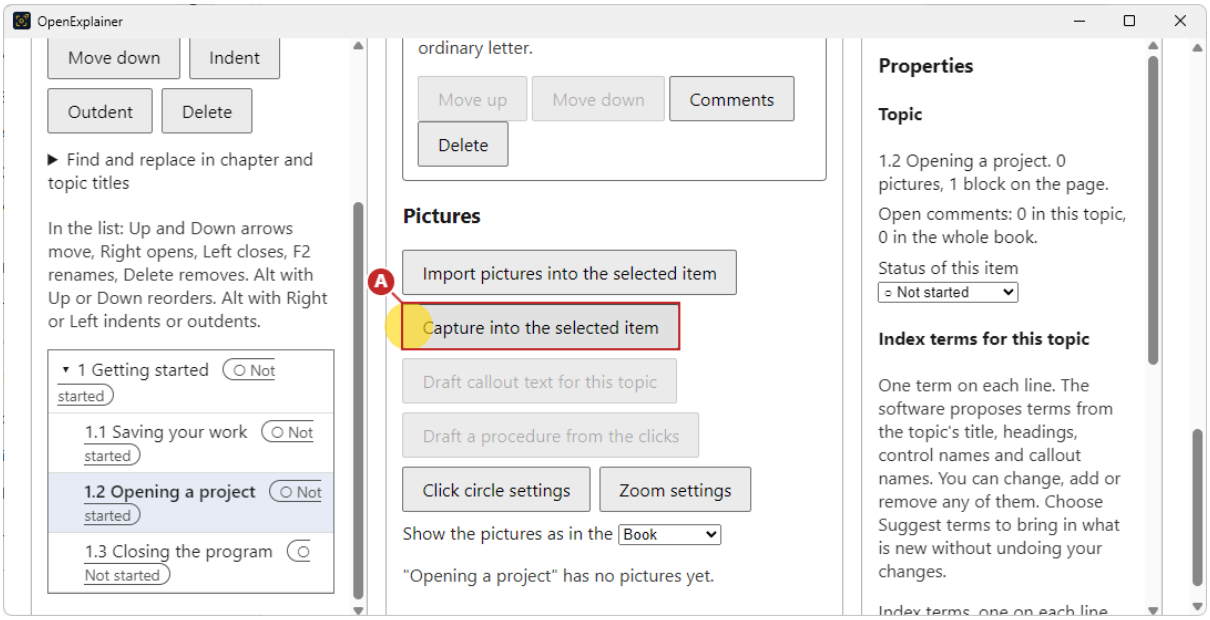
Everything here is for **still pictures**. OpenExplainer never records video, and it never records what you type.

4.1 Capturing a window

Use this when you want a picture of **one program's window**. OpenExplainer hides itself while it captures, so it is never in the picture. A window that other windows cover can still be captured, because Windows is asked to draw that window itself.

1. In the list on the left, select the topic that the picture belongs to.

2. Click **Capture into the selected item**.



A. Capture into the selected item: Opens the Capture window, where you choose what to capture.

Result: A window called Capture asks what you want to capture.

3. Choose **A window**.
4. Click the program's window in the list called Open windows.

   Result: Each entry gives the window's title, the program's name and its size. A window that belongs to another window, such as the Save or Open window of the program, is in the list too.

5. Click **Capture**.

   Result: OpenExplainer hides for a moment, takes the picture and comes back. The picture is in the topic's list of pictures.

A window that is **minimized** has to be restored first, and the list says so. If the program's title bar comes out grey, because it was not the active window, tick **Bring the window to the front first**. That draws it as the active window, but it changes which window is on top for a moment.

If you need a moment to get the other program ready, type a number in **Wait before capturing, in seconds** (0 to 60). OpenExplainer hides, a small Cancel window counts down, and the picture is taken when it reaches 0. A capture normally takes a fraction of a second. If one takes longer, press the Cancel button in the small Cancel window.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> The picture shows exactly what is in the window at that moment. Look at each picture before you share the book, in case something private was open.

4.2 Capturing a rectangle of the screen

Use this when the thing you want is **not a whole window**: a part of a window, a menu, or a tool tip. A menu is a window of its own, so a capture of the window leaves it out, but a rectangle of the screen includes it.

1. Click **Capture into the selected item** and choose **A rectangle of the screen**.
2. Choose the screen, if you have more than one.
3. Choose the rectangle. You can type four numbers, which are counted in pixels from the top left corner of that screen, or click **Use the whole screen**, or click **Select on the screen**.

   Result: Select on the screen takes a snapshot of the screen you chose and shows it full screen. Drag out the rectangle with the mouse, or use the arrow keys or the four number boxes.
4. Click **Capture**.

To capture a menu, set **Wait before capturing** to a few seconds, click Capture, and then open the menu in the other program before the countdown ends.

> ⚠ **CAUTION**
> A rectangle of the screen shows whatever is in that rectangle, which can be more than one program. Check the picture before you share the book.

4.3 Capturing click by click

This is the fastest way to document a task. You click through the steps in the other program, and OpenExplainer records **every click** as a picture, with a note of what you clicked. Afterwards you keep the pictures you want and describe them.

1. Click **Capture into the selected item** and choose **Click by click**.
2. Click **Start capturing clicks**.

   Result: OpenExplainer hides, and a small window with a Stop button shows. It stays on the screen the whole time.
3. Use the other program as the reader would: click through the steps, one at a time.
4. Click **Stop** in the small window.

   Result: A window called Review your clicks opens (see the next topic).

What is and is not recorded

Only mouse clicks are recorded. The keyboard is never watched, and what you type is never recorded. A click on a password box is noted only as *a password box*. The name of what you clicked is kept for buttons, menus and similar controls, but not for list items, text boxes,

documents, tabs or links, because those names can be private.

Each picture is taken just before the program reacts to the click, so it shows what the reader sees at the moment of the click. It stops by itself after 10 minutes with no click, or after 200 clicks, and you keep the clicks it has captured.

> ⚠ **CAUTION**
> The pictures from the Capture window show **everything on your screen**, not only the program. They are only kept in the project if you keep them, so close private windows before you start, and throw away any picture that shows something it should not.

> **TIME SAVER**
> Click slowly and one thing at a time, and wait for the program to react before you click again. Do one task per capture, so each set of pictures becomes one numbered procedure.

4.4 Reviewing your clicks

When you press Stop, a window called **Review your clicks** lists every click that was captured. It says how many clicks there were, and shows each one as a small picture with a note of what was clicked, such as *Click on the button Save*.

1. Look through the list, and untick the pictures you do not want.
2. Describe each picture you keep, in the box beside it.

   Result: A description is read aloud by a screen reader. You can leave it empty and add it later. It is never filled in for you.
3. Click **Add the kept pictures**.

   Result: The pictures are added to the topic, in the order you clicked.

If you click **Throw them all away**, nothing is added and the clicks are forgotten.

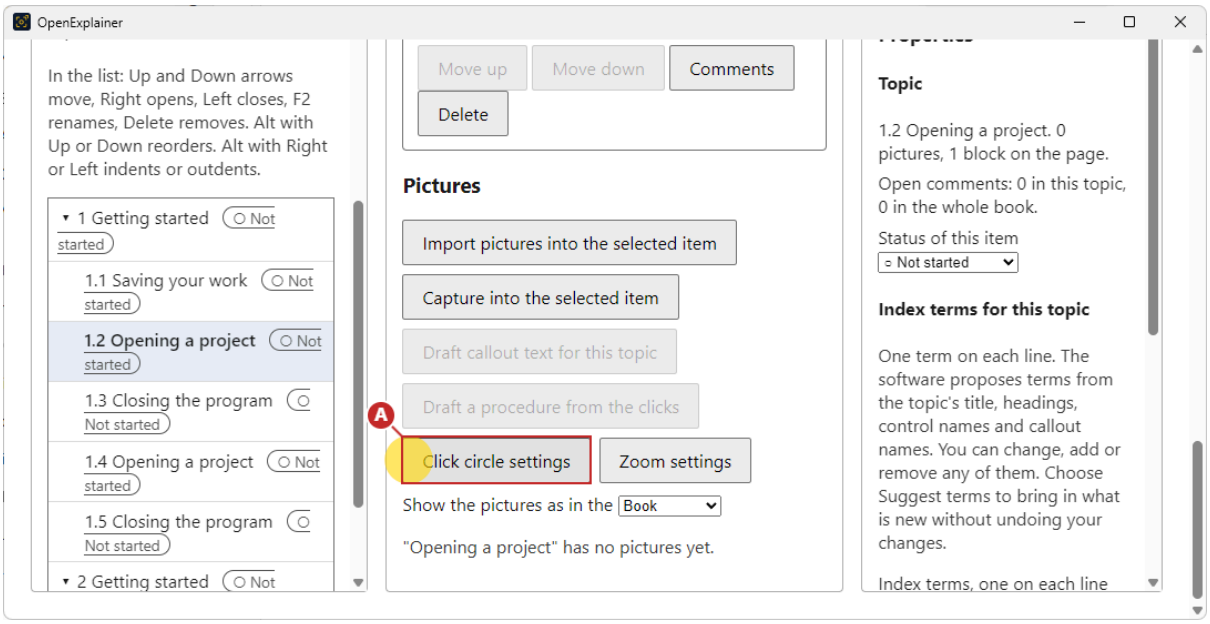
Every kept picture that has an outline of the clicked item also gets a first **callout** by itself, named from the item's name when the name was kept. When the click was on the window itself, so that Windows could not say what was clicked, the callout is a small box round the click, with no name for you to give. Chapter 5 shows how to work with callouts. Then press **Draft a procedure from the clicks** in the Pictures area, and OpenExplainer writes a numbered step for each picture from your click notes, with no AI. It waits in Drafts until you accept it.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
> The steps it writes say Click for a button, Choose for a menu item and Tick for a check box. They never describe typing, because a capture does not record it. Add that yourself.

4.5 The click circle

A transparent **click circle** can be drawn on the spot of every click, so the reader sees exactly where to click. The circle is drawn from the click's position when the book is made. It is never drawn into the picture itself, so you can turn it on, off or move it whenever you like.

1. Click **Click circle settings**.



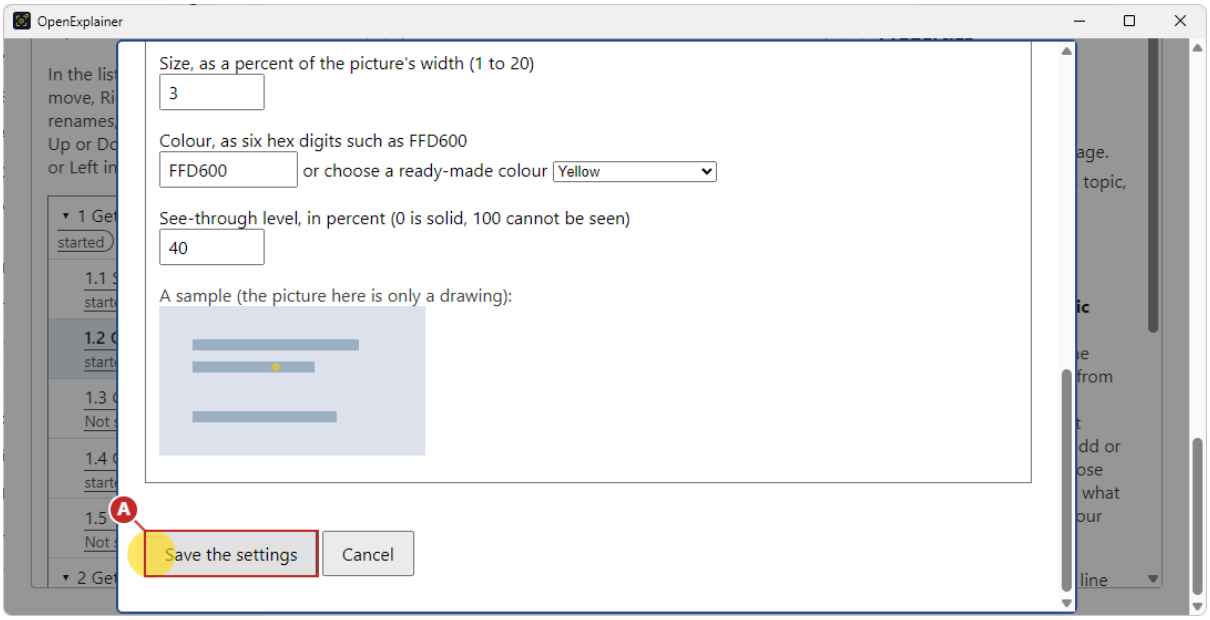
A. Click circle settings: Opens the settings for the circle drawn where a click happened.

Result: A window shows the settings, one set for the book and one for a quick guide.

2. Tick the box to show the circle in the book, and choose its size, its colour and how see-through it is.

Result: A small sample picture shows how the circle will look.

3. Click **Save the settings**.



A. Save the settings: Keeps the circle settings and closes the window.

Result: The settings are kept with the project.

Size is a percent of the picture's width (1 to 20). **Colour** is six hex digits such as FFD600, or a ready-made colour: Yellow, Orange, Green, Blue, Pink, Red or White. **See-through level** is a percent, where 0 is solid and 100 cannot be seen.

Each click picture in the list also has its own choice called **Click circle**: *Follow the project setting*, *Always show* or *Never show*. Beside it, **Move the circle** opens a window where you type a different place for the circle, and *Put it back on the click* undoes that. Above the list of pictures, *Show the pictures as in the* Book or Quick guide lets you see them as they will look in each place.

> ✎ **DESIGN TIP**
>
> A circle about 4 percent wide in the default yellow is easy to see without hiding what was clicked.

4.6 Importing pictures you already have

You can also bring in pictures you already have, from another screenshot tool or from a designer. OpenExplainer accepts **PNG** and **JPEG** pictures.

1. Choose the topic, and click **Import pictures into the selected item**.

   Result: Windows shows its own dialog for choosing files. You can choose more than one.

2. Choose the pictures and click Open in the dialog.

   Result: A window called Describe the picture asks what each one shows.

3. Describe each picture, or leave the box empty to do it later.

   Result: A picture with no description is marked *Needs a description* in the list until you write one.

An imported picture has no click note, so it has no first callout and no click circle. You can still add callouts by hand (Chapter 5), and use the picture in a step or as a picture block.

> ⚠ **CAUTION**
> OpenExplainer copies the picture into your project. If you later change the original file, the book keeps the copy it made.

CHAPTER 5

Explaining your pictures

In This Chapter

- Describing a picture for readers who cannot see it
- Callouts
- Showing only part of a picture
- Drawing marks on a picture

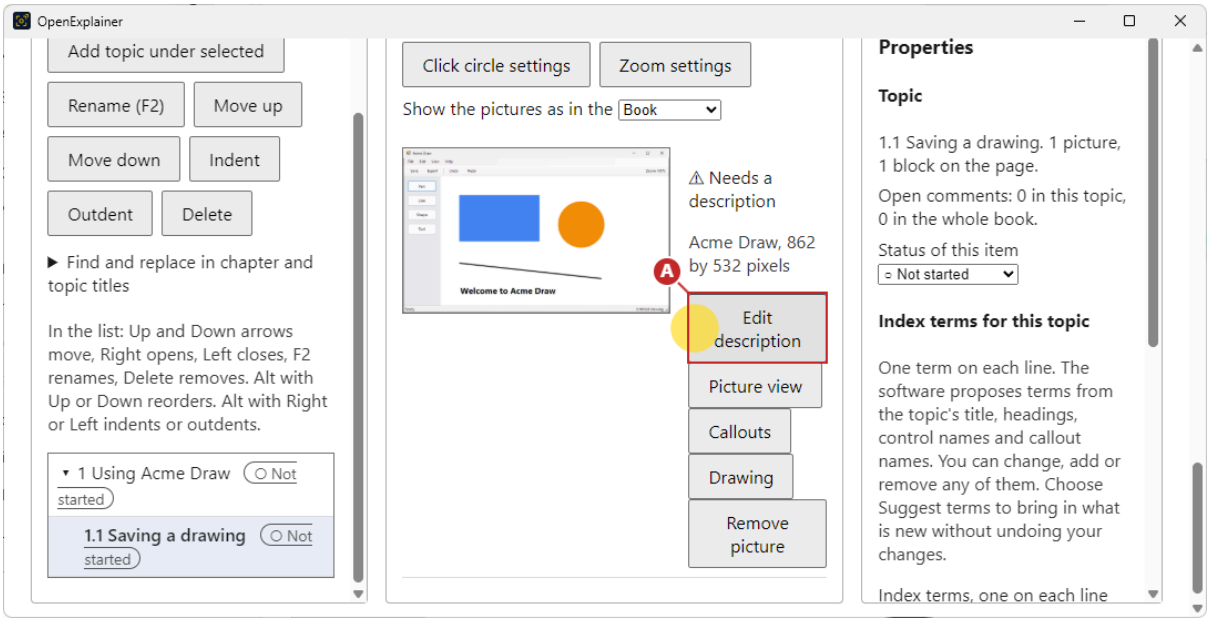
A picture shows what a program looks like. It does not say what to look at, or what it is for, and it says nothing at all to a reader who cannot see it. This chapter covers the four things that turn a picture into an explanation: a **description**, **callouts**, a **view** and **marks**.

The pictures in this chapter use a made-up drawing program called **Acme Draw**, so that nothing private is on the screen. Every picture was taken, described and marked with the tools this chapter explains.

5.1 Describing a picture for readers who cannot see it

A **description** says what a picture shows, in words. A screen reader reads it aloud to a reader who cannot see the picture. OpenExplainer never fills one in for you: it asks, and you write it.

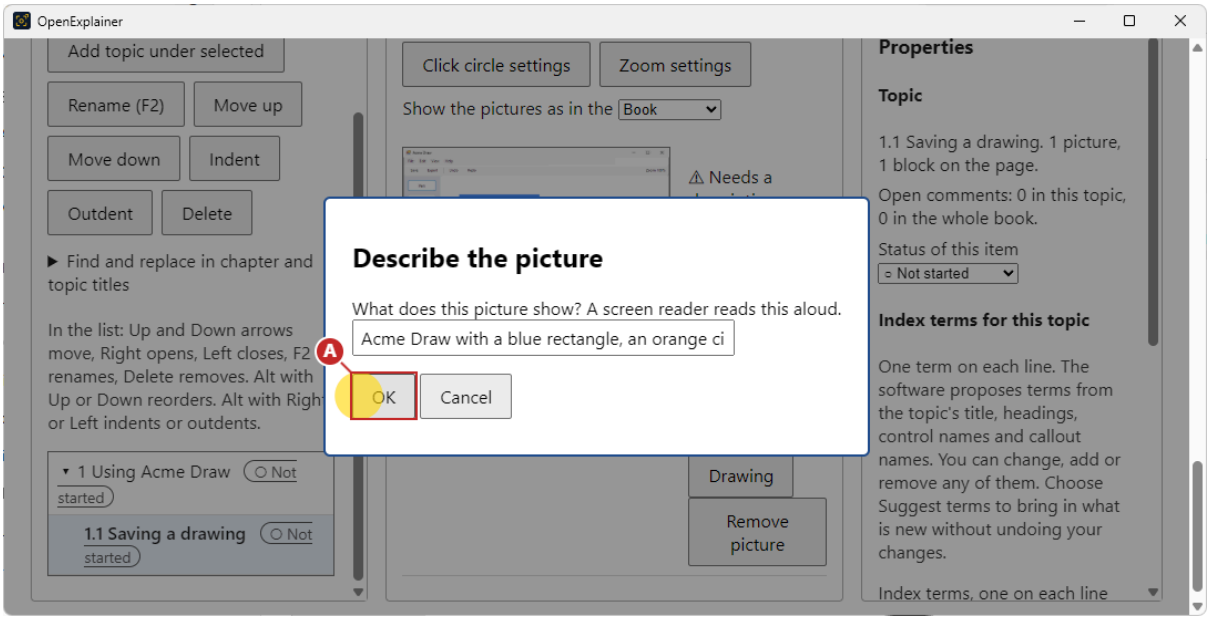
1. Find the picture in the list called Pictures, under the page. A picture with no description says *Needs a description*. Click **Edit description**.



A. Edit description: Opens a window where you say what the picture shows.

Result: A window called Describe the picture opens.

2. Type what the picture shows, and click **OK**.



A. OK: Keeps the description.

Result: The list now shows your words after the word *Description*, in place of the warning.

Writing a good description

Say what the picture shows and what matters about it for the task, in one or two sentences. Name the program and the parts that the reader will use. Do not start with *a picture of* or *a screenshot of*, because a screen reader already says that it is a picture.

The words of the step are the place for what to do, so the description should not repeat them. The callouts (next topic) name the individual parts, so the description does not need to list every button either.

For example, the picture of Acme Draw in this chapter is described like this: *Acme Draw with a blue rectangle, an orange circle and a line on its canvas. The Save, Export, Undo and Redo buttons are above the canvas, and the Pen, Line, Shape and Text tools are on the left.*

Where descriptions go

The description is the alternative text of the picture in every output: the print preview, the PDF (which is tagged, so a screen reader finds each picture as a figure), the Word file, the help site and Markdown. The words on any marks you draw (topic 5.4) are added to it. In a short guide, a picture with no description of its own uses the words of its step.

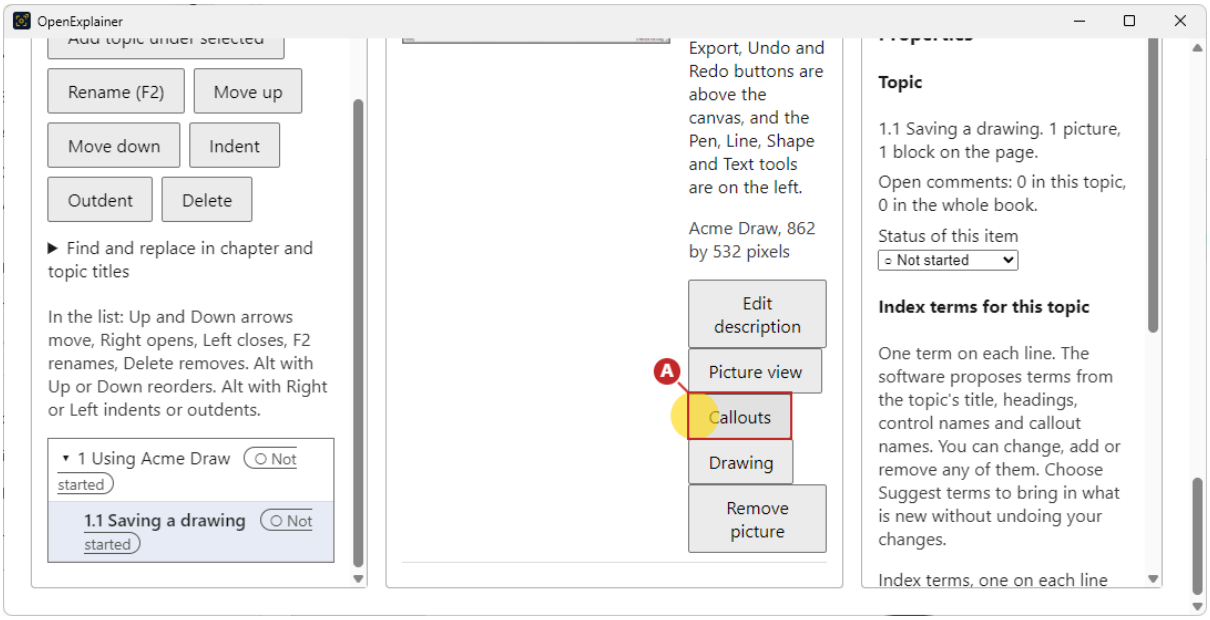
> **⚠ CAUTION**
> A picture with no description is the most common accessibility problem in a book. The book check (Chapter 6) lists every one of them.

5.2 Callouts

A **callout** points at one part of a picture. It is drawn as a thin red outline around the part, a line, and a red marker with a white **letter**. Under the picture, a list says what each letter means: its letter, its name and a sentence, such as *A. Save: Saves the drawing*.

Letters belong to **pictures**, and numbers belong to **steps**. Each picture has its own A, B and C, and a procedure's numbers are never letters. You never type a letter: they follow the order of the callouts, and they change by themselves when you move or delete one.

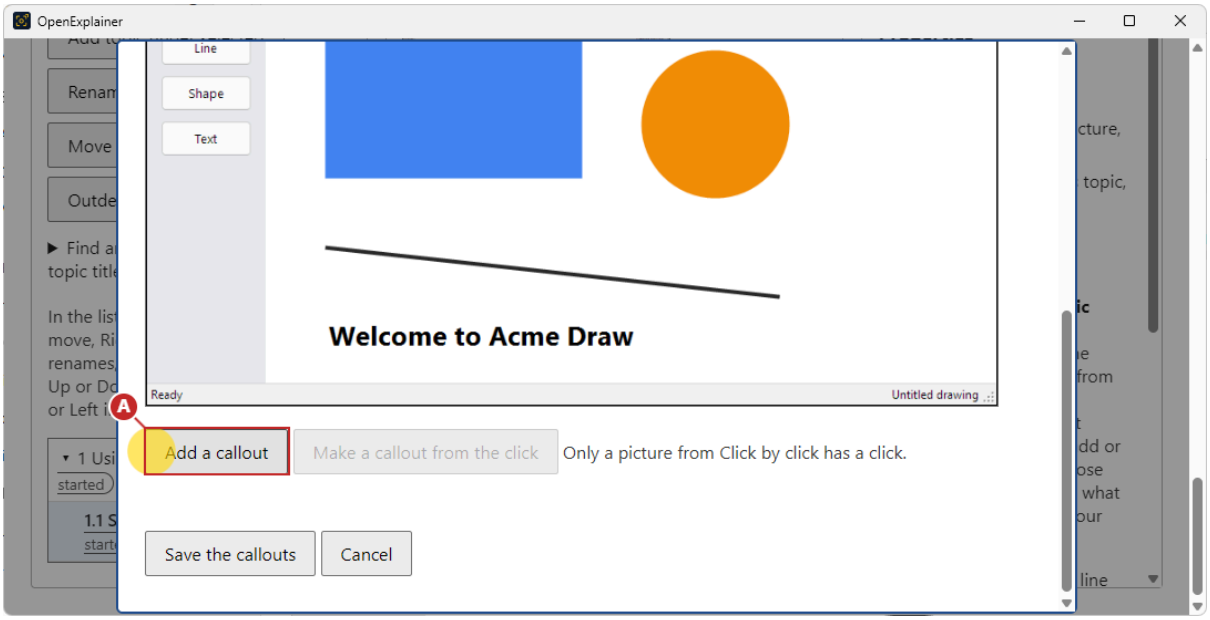
1. Under the picture in the list, click **Callouts**.



A. Callouts: Opens the window where the picture's callouts are made and changed.

Result: A window called Callouts opens, with a sample of the picture.

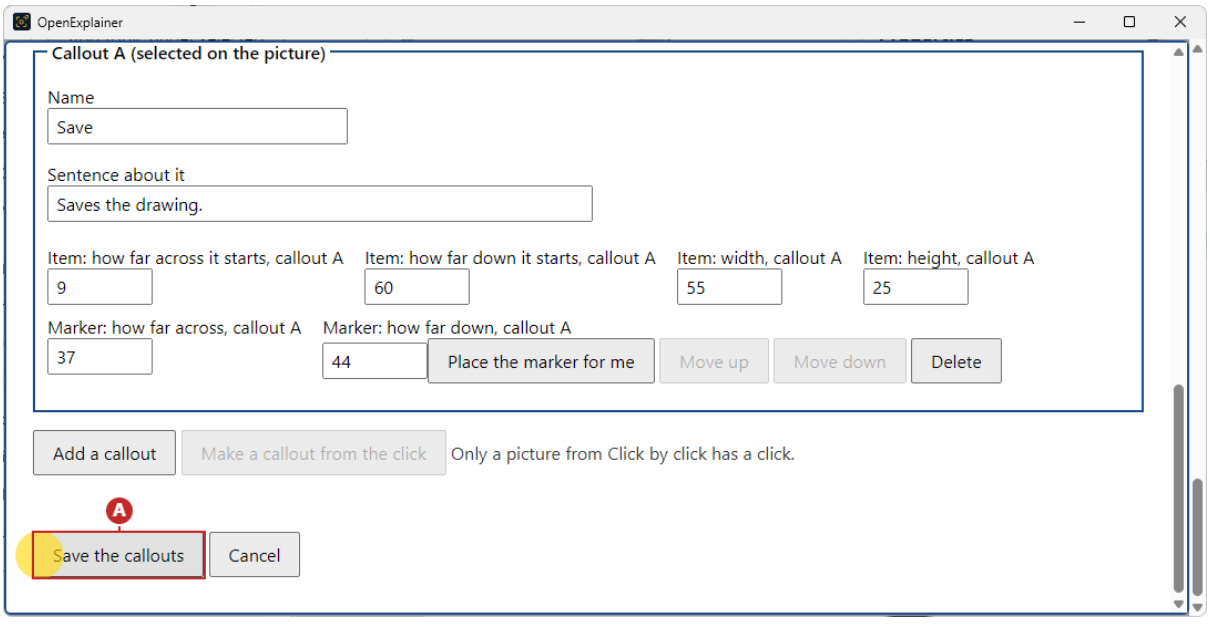
2. Click **Add a callout**.



A. Add a callout: Adds a new callout to the picture.

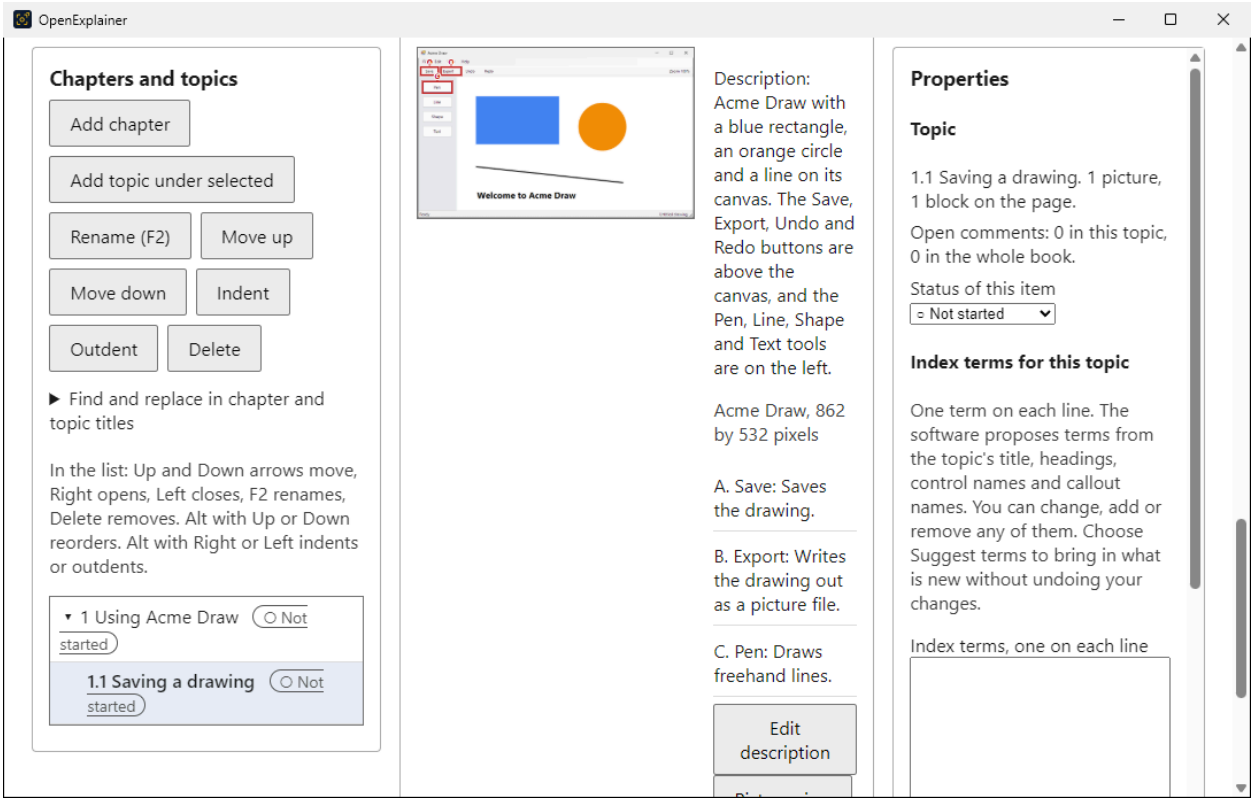
Result: A group of boxes for callout A appears, and an outline appears on the sample.

3. Type the name of the part and a sentence about it. Place the outline on the part (see below), and click **Save the callouts**.



A. Save the callouts: Keeps the callouts and closes the window.

Result: The callouts appear on the picture, and the entries appear under it.



Placing a callout

There are two ways, and you can mix them. The boxes hold the exact numbers: where the part starts (how far across and how far down) and how wide and high it is, counted in pixels from the top left corner of the picture. A second pair of boxes holds the place of the marker, and **Place the marker for me** puts it next to the part.

Or point on the sample: drag on an empty place to draw the outline, drag the outline to move it, drag a corner to resize it, and drag the marker to move only the marker. Press Escape during a drag to put everything back. Whatever you do on the sample fills in the boxes.

With the keyboard, Tab to the outline or the marker on the sample. An arrow key moves it by 1 pixel, and Shift with an arrow moves it by 10. Control with an arrow makes the outline wider, taller, narrower or shorter. The new place is said in words after a short pause, so a screen reader reports it.

Other buttons in the window

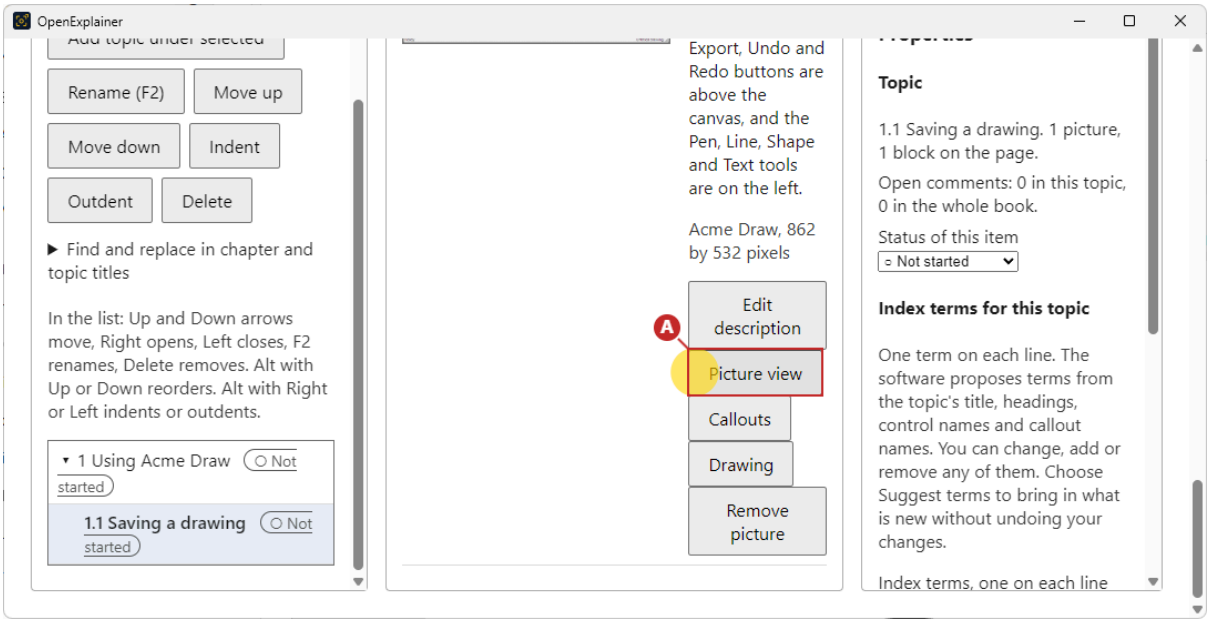
Each callout has **Move up**, **Move down** and **Delete**. **Make a callout from the click** is on only for a picture taken click by click, and only when the clicked item has no callout yet: such a picture already gets callout A by itself (Chapter 4). If the click was on the window itself, callout A is a small box round the click with no name, so that it does not cover the whole picture; give it a name and move it onto the right part. A mistake, such as a word where a number belongs, is explained next to the box, and the window stays open until you put it right. Nothing is kept until you click **Save the callouts**, and **Cancel** or Escape leaves everything as it was.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> A callout with no name or no sentence is shown in words as *needs a name* or *needs a description*, never hidden. The book check lists them too. If the built-in model is on, **Draft callout text** can suggest the sentences (Chapter 8), and you review each one.

5.3 Showing only part of a picture

A whole window is often too wide to read once it is printed, because the writing in it shrinks. A **view** chooses which part of the picture is shown in the book. The picture file itself is **never cut**, so you can change the view or take it off at any time, and the callouts and the click circle always line up with what is shown.

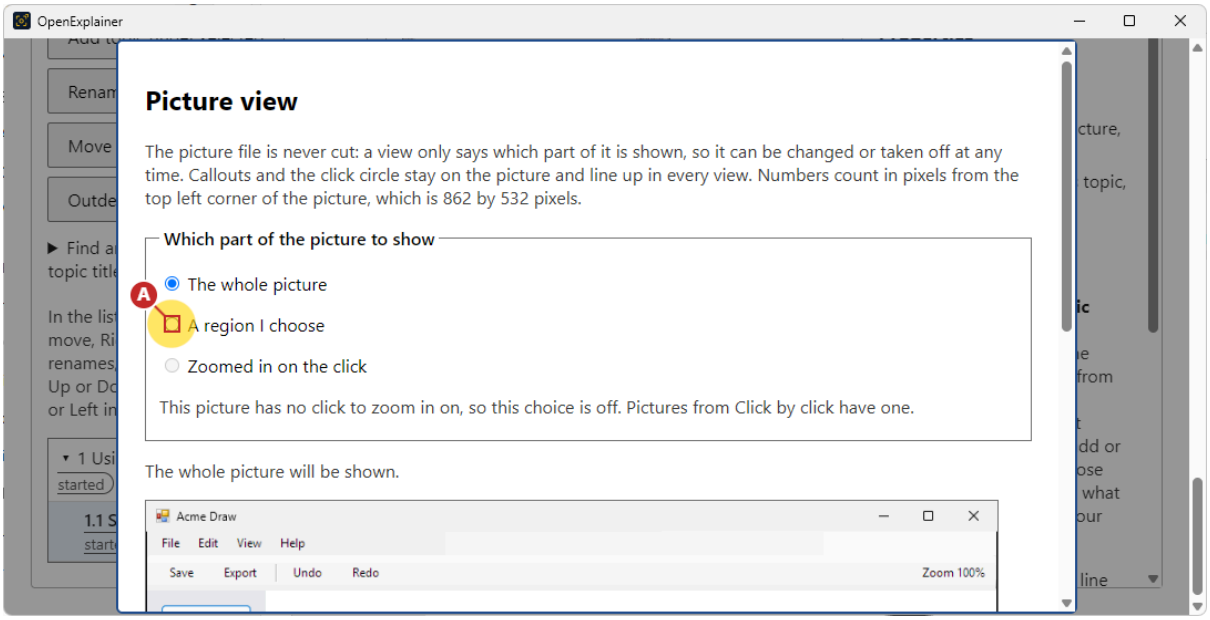
1. Under the picture in the list, click **Picture view**.



A. Picture view: Opens the window where you choose which part of the picture is shown.

Result: A window called Picture view opens, with a sample of the whole picture.

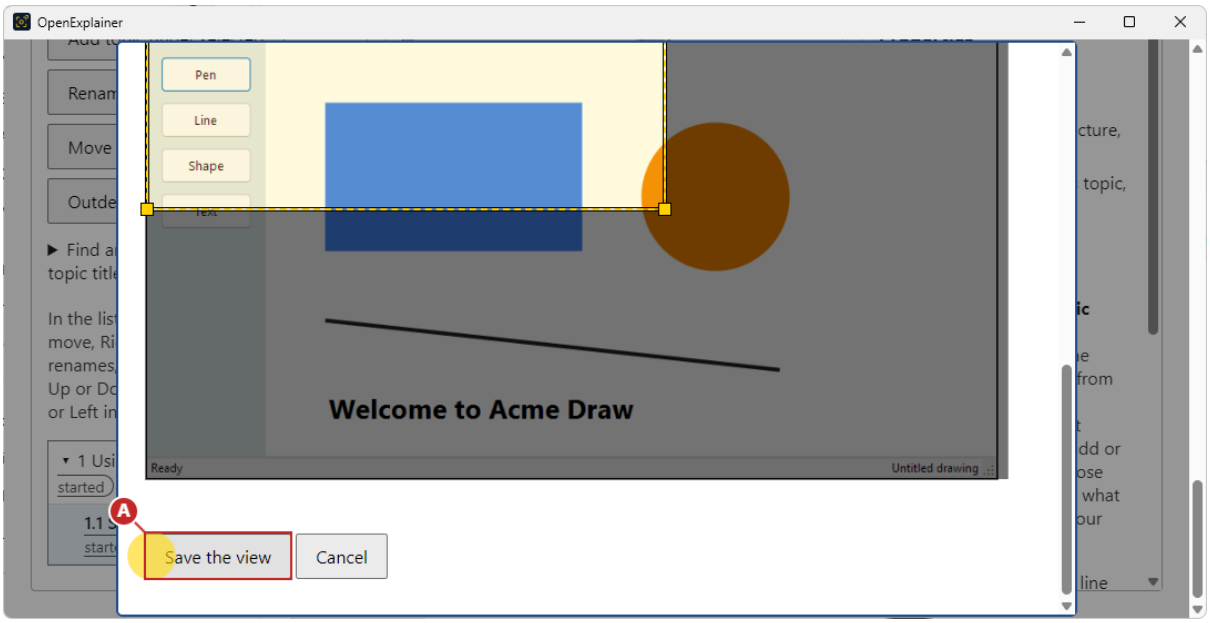
2. Choose **A region I choose**.



A. A region I choose: Shows only a part of the picture, which you describe with four numbers or by pointing.

Result: Four boxes appear for the region, and a bright outline shows it on the sample. The rest of the sample is dimmed.

3. Type where the region starts and how wide and high it is, or drag it on the sample. Then click **Save the view**.



A. Save the view: Keeps the choice and closes the window.

Result: The picture in the list and in the book now shows only that part.

The three choices

The whole picture is how every picture starts. **A region I choose** shows the part you give, counted in pixels from the top left corner, and starts at the middle half of the picture. **Zoomed in on the click** is for pictures taken click by click: the part is centred on the click, and its size is a project setting (see below). It is switched off, with the reason, for a picture that has no click.

A line under the picture in the list says the view in words, for example *Picture view: cropped to 520 by 230 pixels, starting 0 across and 30 down*. A callout that is wholly outside the part shown is not drawn, and its entry says so in words.

Zoom settings and automatic zoom

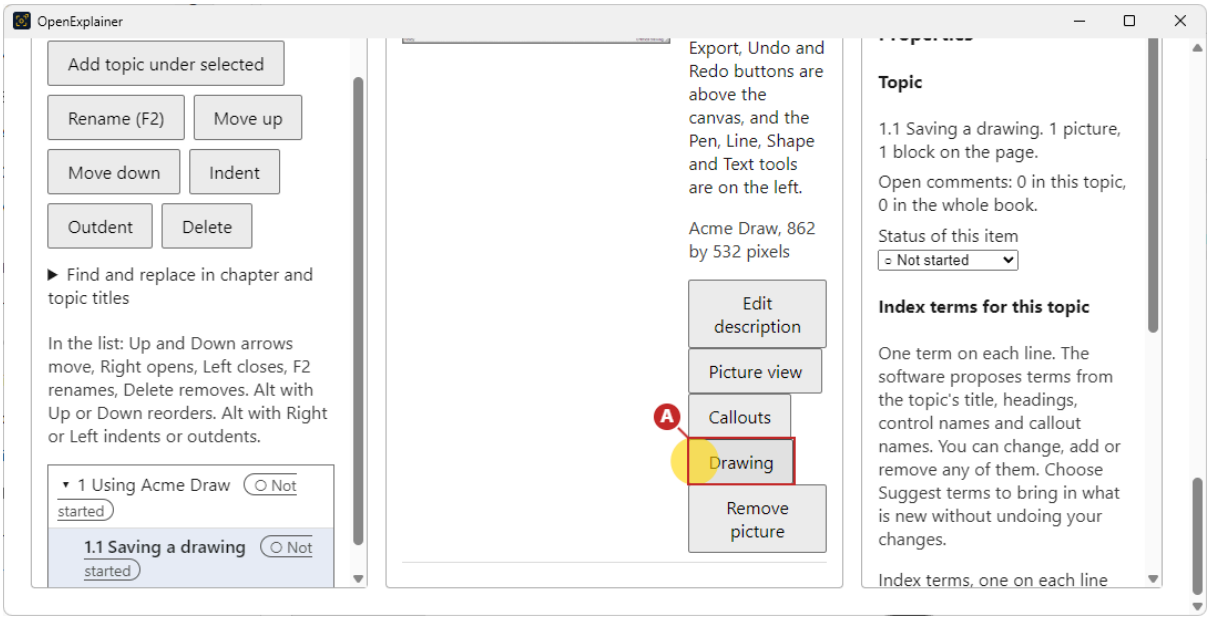
Zoom settings, beside Click circle settings, holds the width of a zoomed part as a percent of the picture's width, one for the book and one for a quick guide. It also has the box **Zoom in on the click automatically when a picture would print too small**. When it is ticked, the printed outputs (the PDF and the Word file) zoom in on the click by themselves for any click picture that would print below half its size on screen. Your own crop or zoom always wins over it.

> ϟ **POWER TIP**
>
> Open the Print preview tab and look at the notes for the writer above it. It lists every picture that will print too small, so you know where a view would help.

5.4 Drawing marks on a picture

A **mark** is something you draw on a picture to help the reader: an **arrow**, a **text box**, a **rectangle** or a **numbered marker**. Marks are kept beside the picture and drawn over it when the book is made, under the lettered callouts. The picture itself is never changed, so a mark can be moved, reworded or removed later.

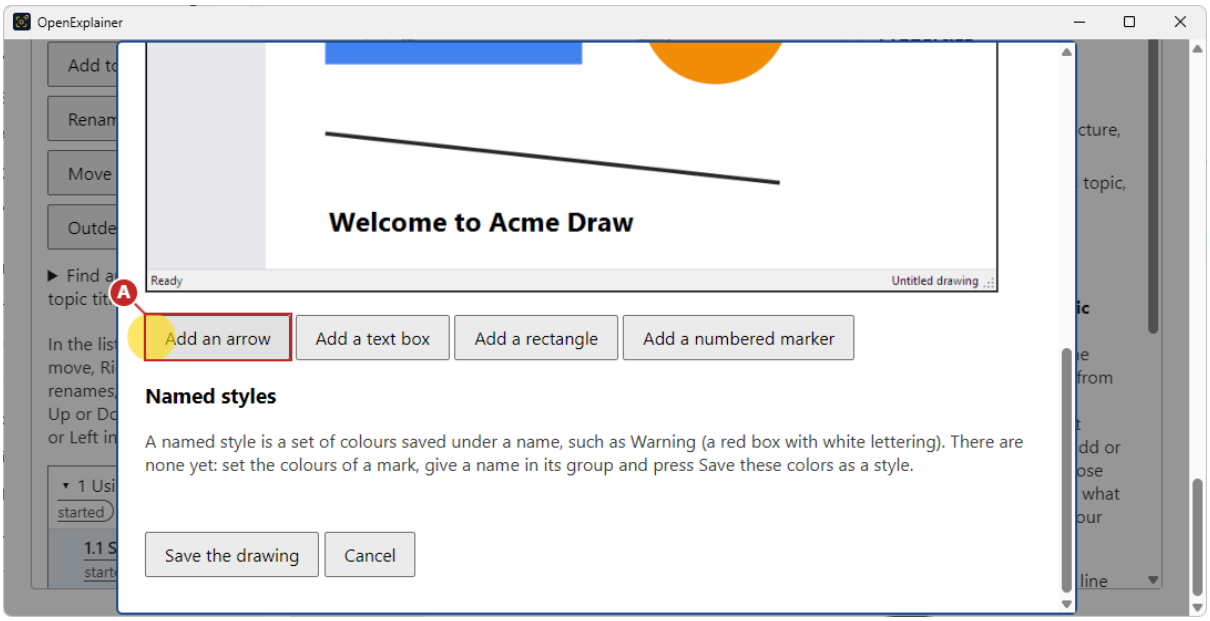
1. Under the picture in the list, click **Drawing**.



A. Drawing: Opens the window where arrows, text boxes, rectangles and numbered markers are drawn on the picture.

Result: A window called Drawing opens, with a sample of the picture and four buttons for adding marks.

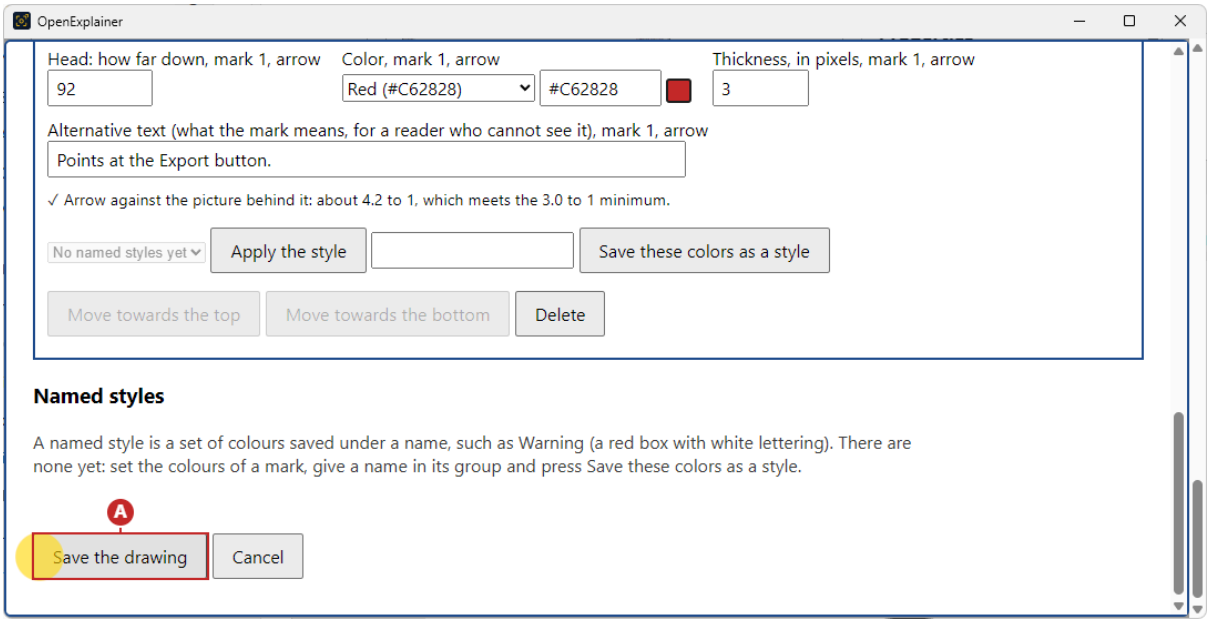
2. Click **Add an arrow**. Fill in its boxes, or drag it on the sample.



A. Add an arrow: Adds an arrow that you place and describe.

Result: The arrow appears on the sample, and its boxes appear below.

3. Say in the alternative text box what the arrow means for a reader who cannot see it, and click **Save the drawing**.



A. Save the drawing: Keeps the marks and closes the window.

Result: The arrow is drawn on the picture in the list, and the list says how many marks the picture has.

Which mark to use

An **arrow** points at something from a distance, and has a tail, a head and a thickness. A **text box** puts a few words right on the picture. A **rectangle** outlines or shades an area, and can have a see-through fill. A **numbered marker** is a small circle with a label of one to three letters or digits, for a sequence of things in one picture.

Use a **callout** (topic 5.2) when a part needs a name and a sentence in the list under the picture. Use a **mark** when you only need to point, or when the words belong on the picture itself.

Colours, contrast and alternative text

Each colour is chosen from ten ready-made swatches (Red, Orange, Yellow, Green, Blue, Purple, Black, White, Dark gray and Light gray) or typed as six hex digits such as C62828. As soon as you choose one, the window says in words, with a tick or a warning sign, how well it can be seen: text against its fill needs 4.5 to 1, and an arrow, outline or marker against the picture behind it needs 3 to 1. It only **warns**. You can keep any colour you like, and the check never stops you.

Every mark has a box for alternative text, and a mark with none says so under its boxes. The words of a text box and the labels of markers are added to the picture's description automatically.

If you use the same colours often, choose a mark's colours, type a name and click **Save these colors as a style**. Any other mark can then use **Apply the style**. Marks have an order, and **Move towards the top** and **Move towards the bottom** change which one is drawn over which. Nothing is kept until you click **Save the drawing**.

CHAPTER 6

Checking your work

In This Chapter

- The book check
- Words to avoid and consistency

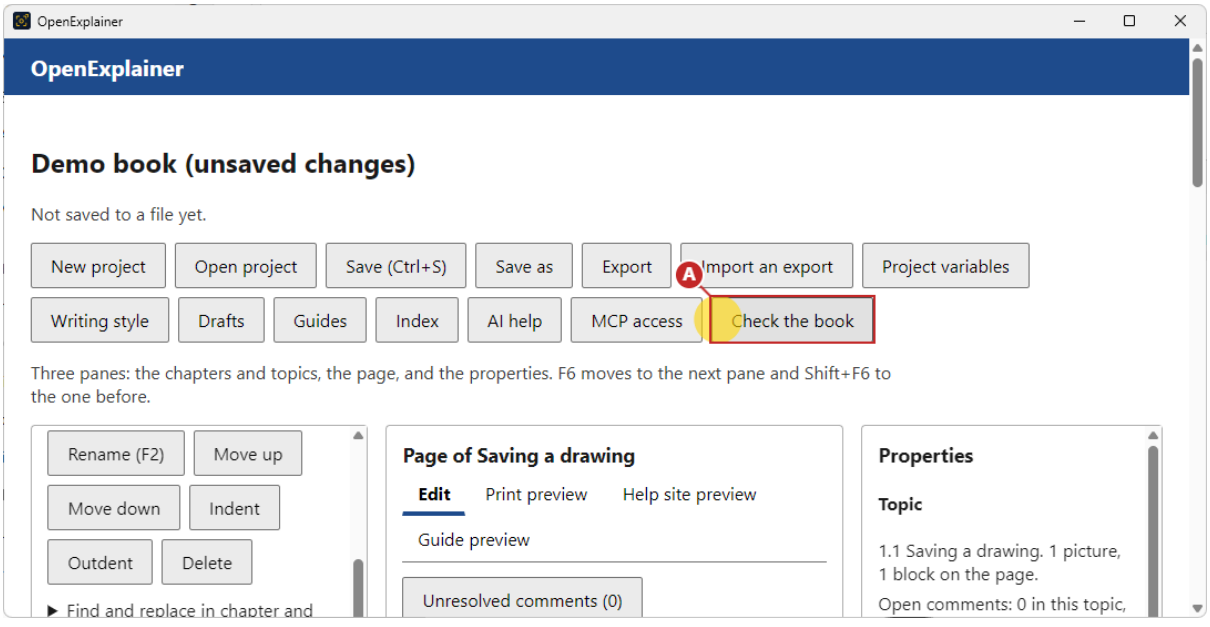
A book is finished when a reader can use it, not when the last page is written. OpenExplainer has two helpers for the last stage: **Check the book**, which looks for things worth fixing, and **Words to avoid**, which keeps your own word choices consistent.

Both are **optional**. They advise and never stop you. Nothing in them blocks saving, exporting or printing, because a choice that looks like a mistake, such as a low-contrast colour, may be exactly what you meant.

6.1 The book check

Check the book reads the whole project and lists what is worth fixing, in reading order. It works from the project alone, so it needs no AI and no internet. It is a button in the toolbar, beside **Project variables**.

1. Click **Check the book**.

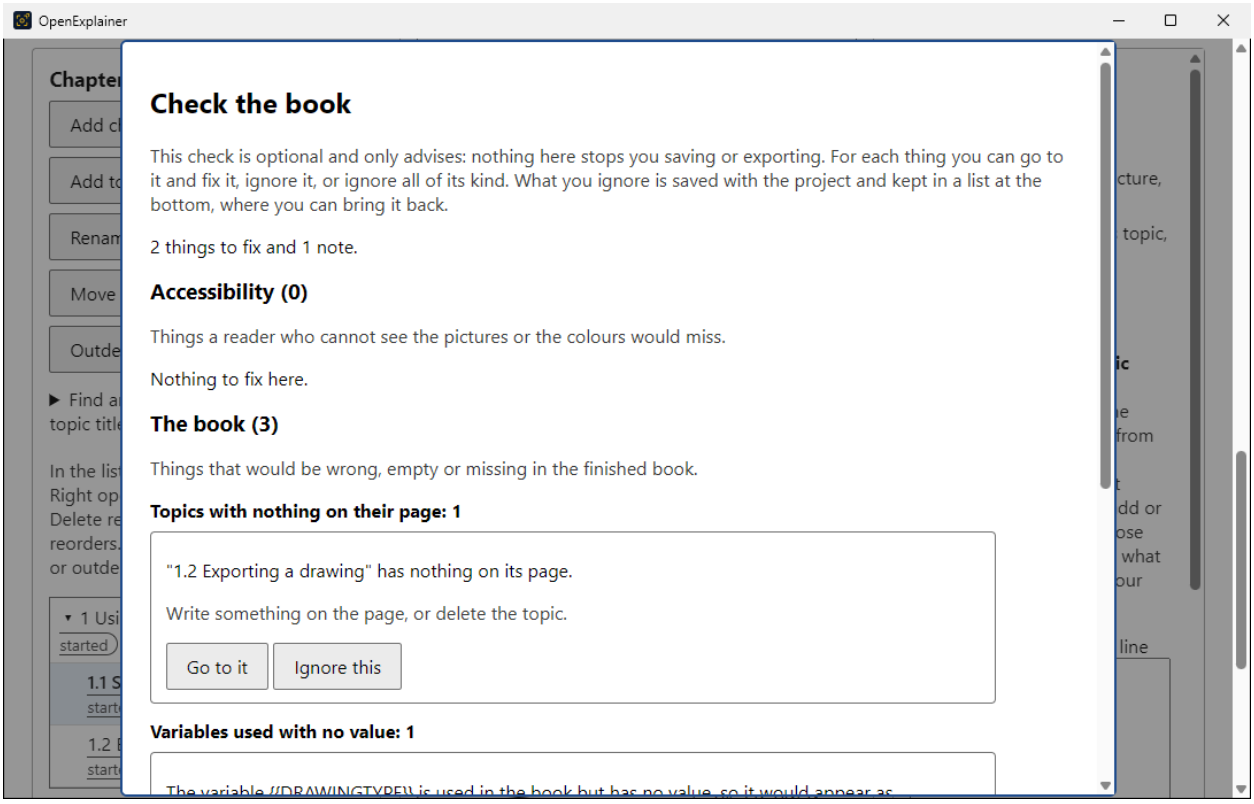


A. Check the book: Opens an optional list of things worth fixing. It never stops you saving or exporting.

Result: A window called Check the book opens. At the top it says in words how many things there are to fix and how many are only notes.

2. Read the list. Each thing is in plain words, with what to do about it, and is under one of two headings: **Accessibility** or **The book**.
3. For each thing, click **Go to it** to fix it, or **Ignore this** if you mean it to be that way.

   Result: Go to it closes the window, selects the topic and puts the keyboard on the control that fixes it.



What it finds

Under **Accessibility**: a picture on a page with no description, an arrow or rectangle with no alternative text, marks whose colours are too close together, a callout with no name or no sentence, and, as a note, a picture that will print too small to read.

Under **The book**: a topic with nothing on its page, an empty block or a step with no words, a picture whose file is missing from the project, and a variable that is used in the book but has no value, so that its name in curly brackets would print. As notes: a picture that is in a topic but not on its page, and a variable that has a value that nothing uses.

Some items are **notes**, not things to fix. They are labelled in words, so nothing depends on colour.

Ignoring things

Ignore this moves one item to an **Ignored** list at the bottom of the window. When a kind has several items, **Ignore all *N* of these** moves them all. **Stop ignoring** brings an item back. What you ignore is saved with the project, so it stays ignored next time.

You can also run the check from inside the Export window, with **Check the book first (optional)**. It is never required.

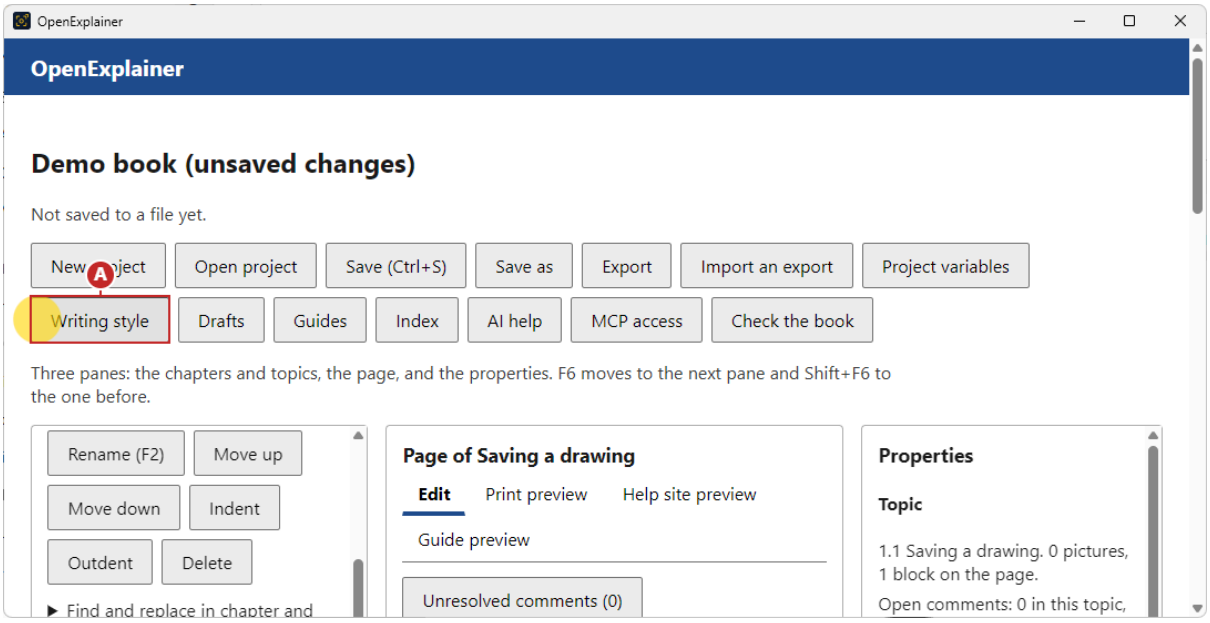
When most of the things to fix are of one kind, the line at the top says so, for example *35 of the things to fix are one kind: Topics with nothing on their page*. An unfinished book has many empty topics, and the list below groups them by kind.

> **TIME SAVER**
> Run the check once when the pages are written and the pictures are in, and again before you export. An unfinished book will show many items. That is normal: use the list as a to-do list.

6.2 Words to avoid and consistency

OpenExplainer can keep your wording consistent without any AI. The **Writing style** button, beside Project variables, opens a window with two boxes.

1. Click **Writing style**.

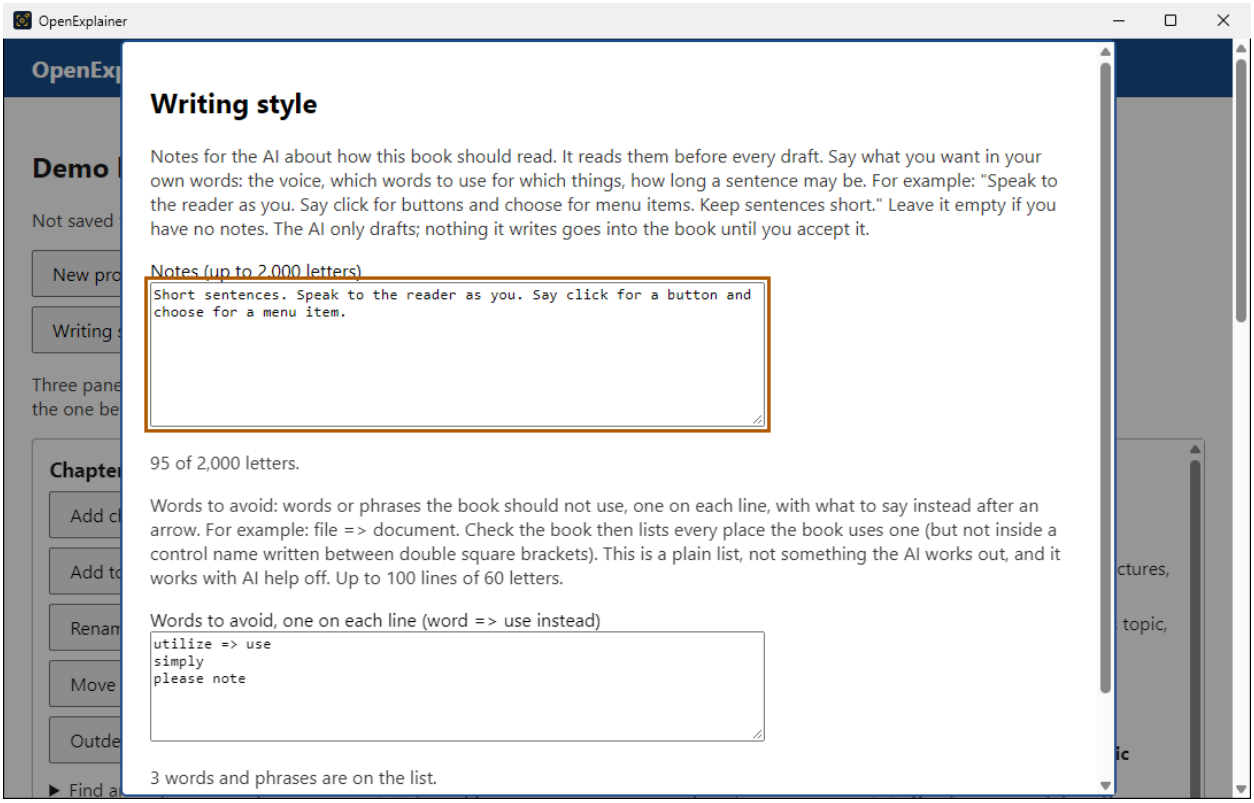


A. Writing style: Opens the notes about how the book should read, and the list of words to avoid.

Result: A window called Writing style opens.

2. In the box called **Words to avoid**, type one word or phrase on each line. After an arrow (=>) you can say what to use instead, for example: utilize => use.

3. Click **Save**.



The book check then lists every place where the book uses one of those words, as a note, with the exact words and where they are. It does **not** look inside a control name written between double square brackets, because that name must match what the program shows on the screen.

The Notes box

The first box, **Notes**, is for the built-in AI. Say in your own words how the book should read: the voice, which words to use for which things, how long a sentence may be. The AI reads the notes before it drafts anything (Chapter 8). With AI help off, the Notes box does nothing, and everything else here still works.

Other consistency notes

When your book has pictures taken click by click, the check can also compare your writing with what the program actually showed. It adds notes for three things. A control name written in double square brackets that differs from the name Windows reported when it was clicked, such as Save as in the text when the program says *Save as…*. A step that starts with a verb that does not suit the kind of control, such as Press for a menu item. And any word or phrase from your Words to avoid list.

> **POWER TIP**
>
> Put your house rules in Words to avoid as you meet them: a word a reviewer keeps changing, or a product name that has to be spelled one way. The list is saved with the project.

CHAPTER 7

Making your outputs

In This Chapter

- The print preview
- A PDF for paper
- A Word file
- A help site
- Markdown and JSON
- Short step-by-step guides
- The index

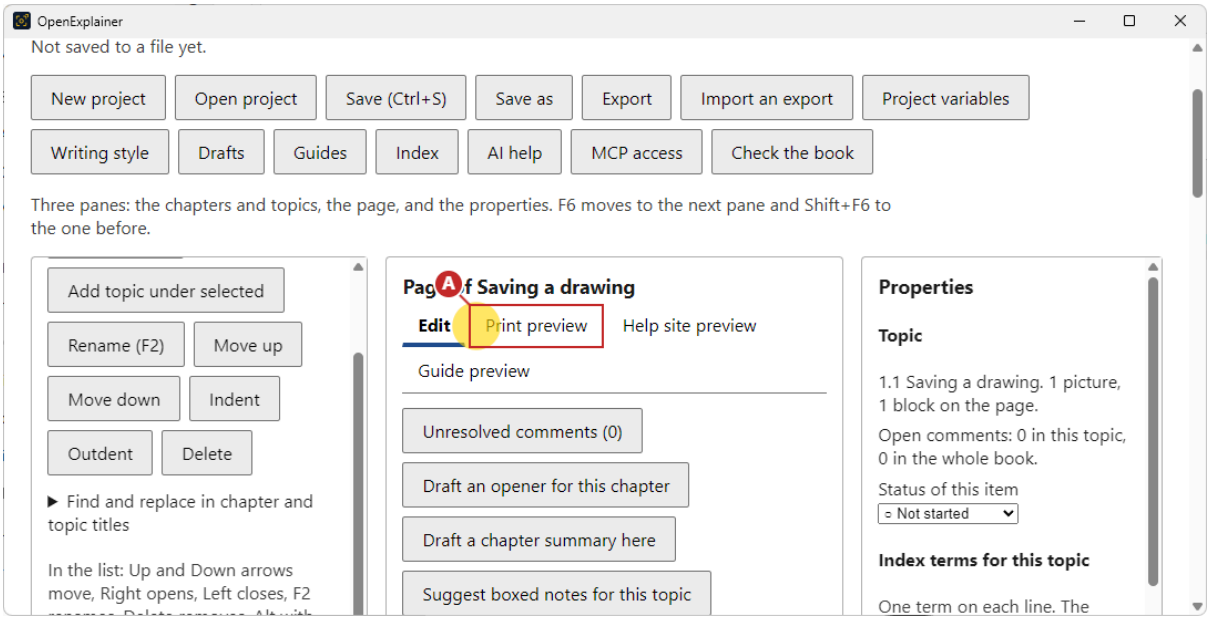
The book you write in OpenExplainer is kept in one project file. Every output is made from that file and never changes it, so you can make a PDF today, edit a topic tomorrow and make it again.

This chapter covers the previews, then each output: the **PDF** and the **Word file** for paper, the **help site** for the web, **Markdown** and **JSON** for other programs, the short **guides**, and the **index** that goes into all of them.

7.1 The print preview

The page pane has four tabs: **Edit**, **Print preview**, **Help site preview** and **Guide preview**. The preview tabs show your book as it will look, so you can check it without making a file.

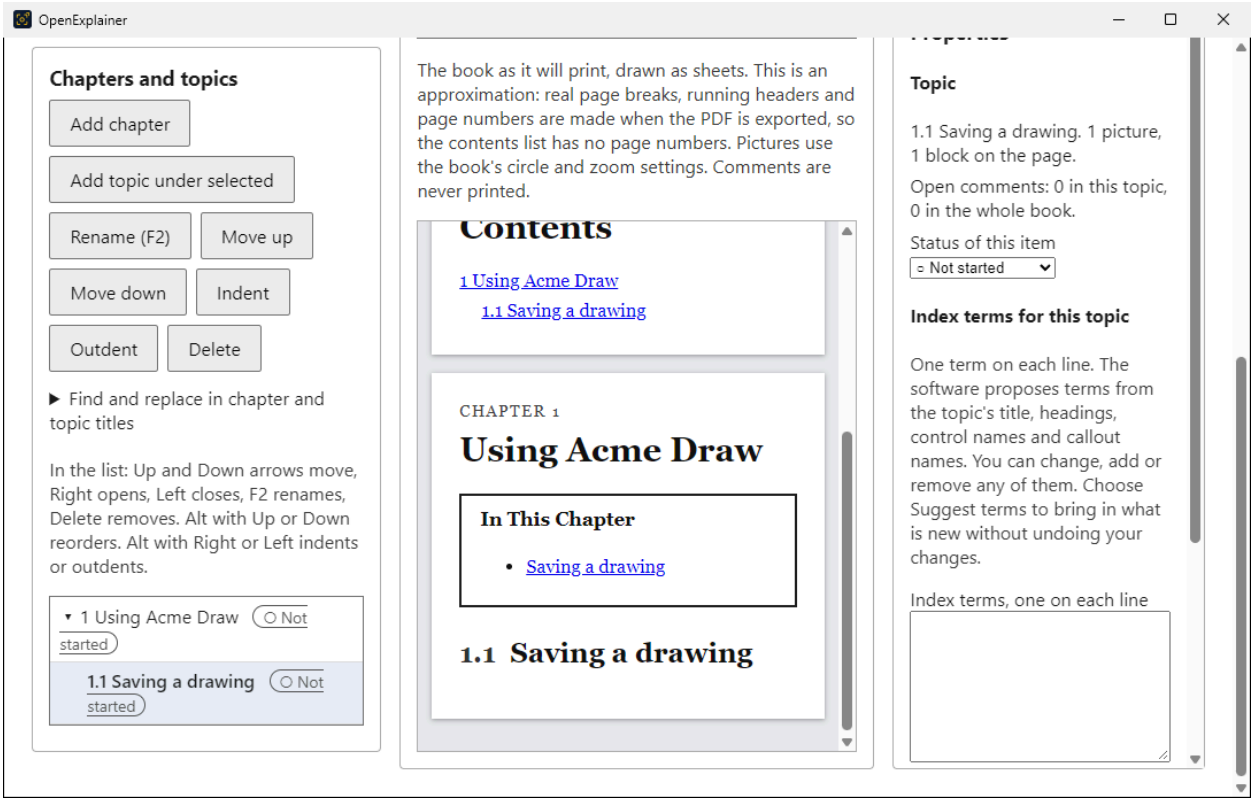
1. Click the **Print preview** tab.



A. Print preview: Shows the whole book as sheets, the way it will be printed.

Result: The page is replaced by the whole book, as sheets: a title page, a contents list, then each chapter.

2. Read down the sheets, or follow a link in the contents to jump to a topic.
3. Click the **Edit** tab to go back to writing.



The tabs work like any tab list: Left and Right move between them, and Home and End go to the first and last. The preview is real page content, not a picture, so a screen reader reads it and its region can be reached and scrolled with the keyboard.

Notes for the writer

Above a preview you may see a line such as *2 notes for the writer (these are not part of the book)*. Open it to see things worth a look: a picture whose writing will print too small, a picture with no description, a callout that lies outside the part of the picture that is shown, or a picture file that is missing. Each sits next to the picture it is about. An export never contains them.

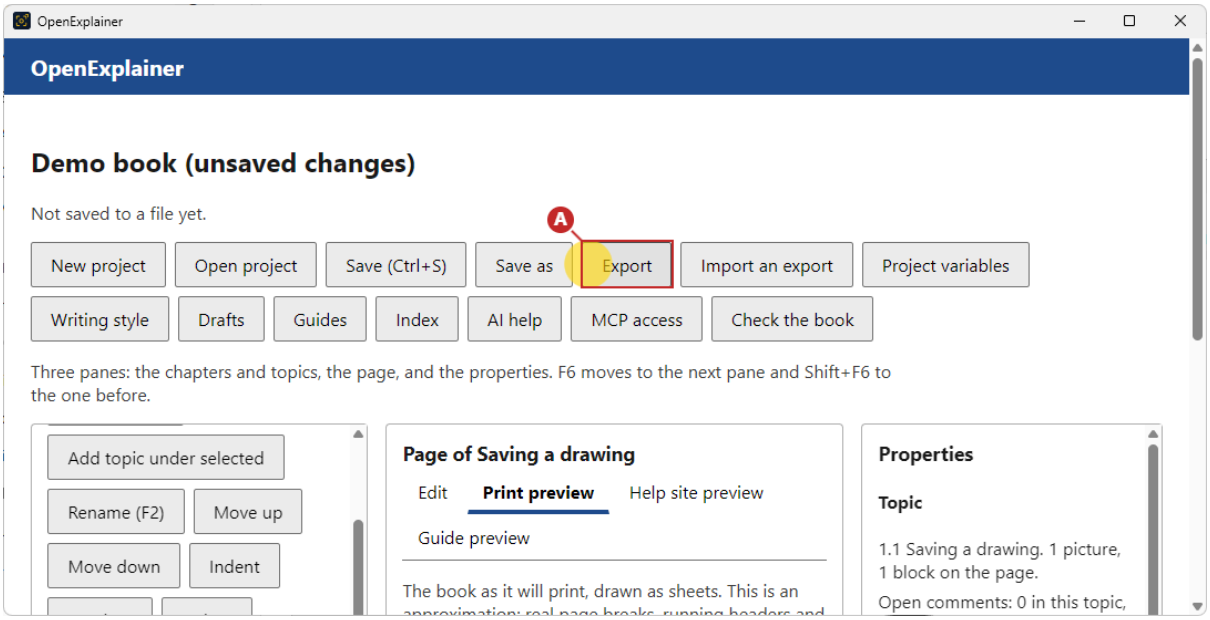
What the previews are

The **print preview** is an approximation of the printed book. Real page breaks, the running header and page numbers belong to the PDF. The **help site preview** shows one topic as a web page, with the contents tree, the breadcrumbs and the Previous and Next links. The **guide preview** shows one short guide (topic 7.6).

7.2 A PDF for paper

The **PDF** is the main output: a book made for paper. It is letter size, with a running header, page numbers and a contents list with page numbers.

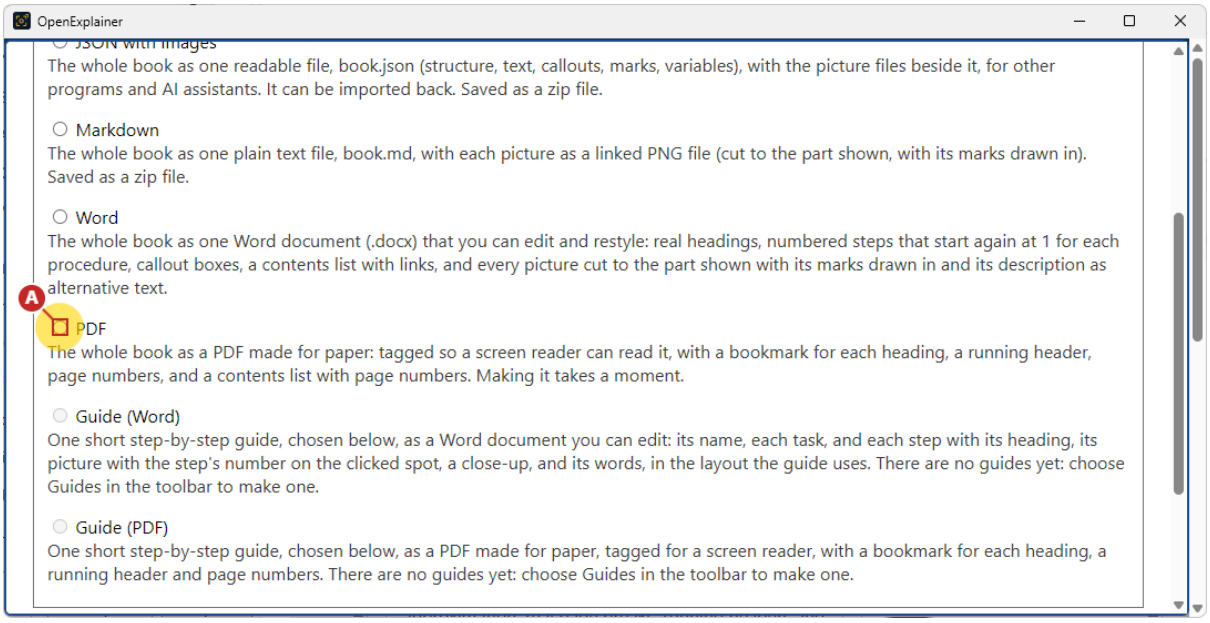
1. Click **Export**.



A. Export: Opens the window where you choose what to make.

Result: A window called Export lists what can be made, with a sentence about each.

2. Choose **PDF**.



A. PDF: Makes the whole book as a PDF for paper, with a contents list and page numbers.

Result: The sentence under it says that the PDF is tagged for a screen reader and has a bookmark for each heading.

3. Click Export at the bottom of the window, and choose where to save the file in Windows' Save window.

   Result: The program makes the PDF, which takes a moment, and then says where the file was saved.

What is in it

The PDF has real text, so it can be searched and selected. It is **tagged** (headings, lists, links and figures), it has the language set to English and the book's name as its title, and a **bookmark** for each heading. Each picture's description is its alternative text.

Each chapter starts on a new page. The title page has no header or page number. Pictures are never split across pages, and a step is kept with its picture where there is room. The contents list has dotted leaders and page numbers. They are found by printing the book more than once, and if the numbers cannot be read out of the finished file, the contents is left without numbers rather than with wrong ones, and the export says so.

Comments and notes for the writer are never in it. Nothing is sent anywhere: the PDF is made on your PC by the same browser engine that shows the program.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
>
> The book's own fonts are Georgia for the text and Segoe UI for the headings, as installed on your PC, and the PDF embeds the ones it used. A PC without them falls back to Times New Roman and Arial.

7.3 A Word file

The **Word** export makes one .docx file that you can edit and restyle. Everything in it is a real Word style, not hand-made formatting, so changing a style changes the whole book.

1. Click **Export** and choose **Word**.
2. Click Export, and choose where to save the .docx file.

   Result: The program says where the file was saved.

The title page holds the book's name and the PRODUCT, VERSION and COMPANY variables. The contents is Word's own table of contents, already filled in with links. It has no page numbers yet, because only Word knows where its pages break: in Word, right-click the contents and choose **Update Field**.

A chapter is Heading 1 and starts a new page, and each topic is one level deeper, so Word's navigation pane works. Chapters that have topics open with an **In This Chapter** list. Each procedure is a numbered list that starts again at 1, with its picture indented under the step and the result line after it.

Pictures are placed in the text, cut to the part shown, with their marks drawn in and their description as alternative text. The callout entries follow each picture as captions, such as *A. Save: Saves the drawing*. Each kind of callout box has its own style, and says its kind in words as well as showing it by a coloured edge.

There is a running header with the book's name and a page number in the footer. Comments are never included.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> If your publisher or your organisation has its own Word template, give it to your editor with this file. Because everything uses real styles, restyling is a matter of changing the styles.

7.4 A help site

The **help site** is a folder of web pages, one for each topic, that you can put on a web server or open from your own PC.

1. Click **Export** and choose **Help site**.
2. Click Export, and choose where to save the zip file.
3. Unzip it, and open the file called index.html.

   Result: The first topic opens, with the contents tree on the left.

Each page has a skip link, a header with the book's name and a search box, the contents tree with the current topic marked, a trail of links above the title, the topic itself, a list of the topics inside it, and Previous and Next links. A **Print this page** button prints just the topic, without the navigation.

The links between pages are ordinary links, so the site works with no script. The only script is for the search box and the Print this page button. Search looks at every word of every topic, ranks title matches first, says in words how many topics match, and puts the keyboard on the results. The search also works when the pages are opened straight from a folder.

The pages are made by the same code as the **Help site preview**, so the preview shows what you will get. If the book has an index, every page links to an **Index** page.

7.5 Markdown and JSON

Markdown and **JSON** are for other programs: a documentation tool that reads Markdown, or an AI assistant that reads the JSON.

Markdown

Choose **Markdown** in the Export window. You get a zip file with one text file, book.md, and the pictures as PNG files. The title is a heading, then a contents list, then each chapter and topic as a heading one level deeper than the one before. A numbered procedure is a numbered list, a callout box is a quotation that starts with its kind in bold, and each picture is a linked image whose text is its description, followed by its callout entries as a list.

JSON with images

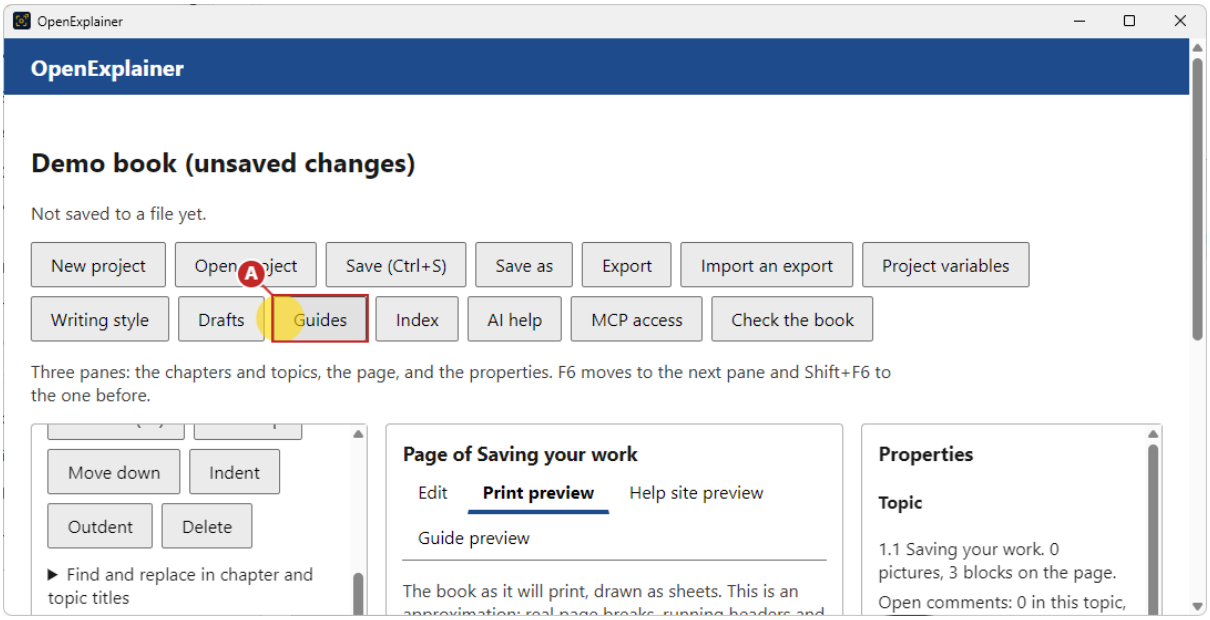
Choose **JSON with images**. You get a zip file with book.json and the project's own picture files. The JSON holds the structure of the book, its text, the callouts, the marks, the variables and the settings. It is meant to be read by another program, and it can be brought back with **Import an export** in the toolbar.

Working comments are left out unless you tick **Include the working comments in the JSON export**. An export that is damaged, or made by a newer version of the program, is refused in plain words and nothing is changed. An imported book counts as unsaved until you save it.

7.6 Short step-by-step guides

A **guide** is a few pages for one task, or for several: the quick handout rather than the book. A guide holds **no text of its own**. It is a list of topics that are already in your book, with a layout and a few choices. So you write each step once, and editing the topic changes the book and every guide made from it.

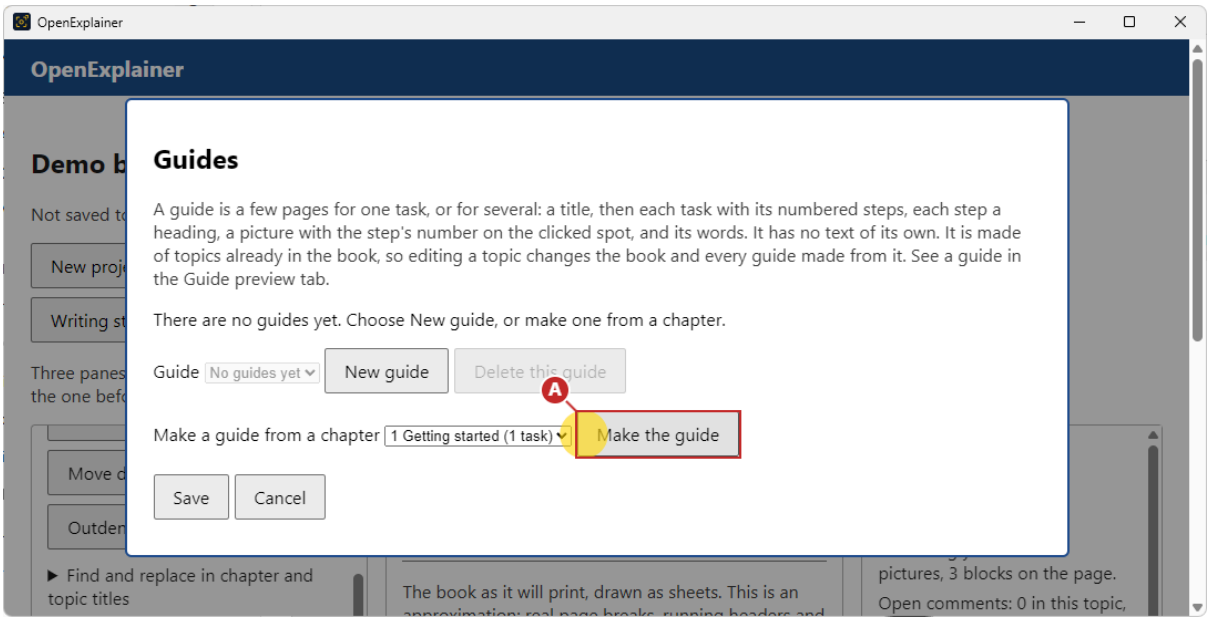
1. Click **Guides**.



A. Guides: Opens the window where short step-by-step guides are made and changed.

Result: A window called Guides opens.

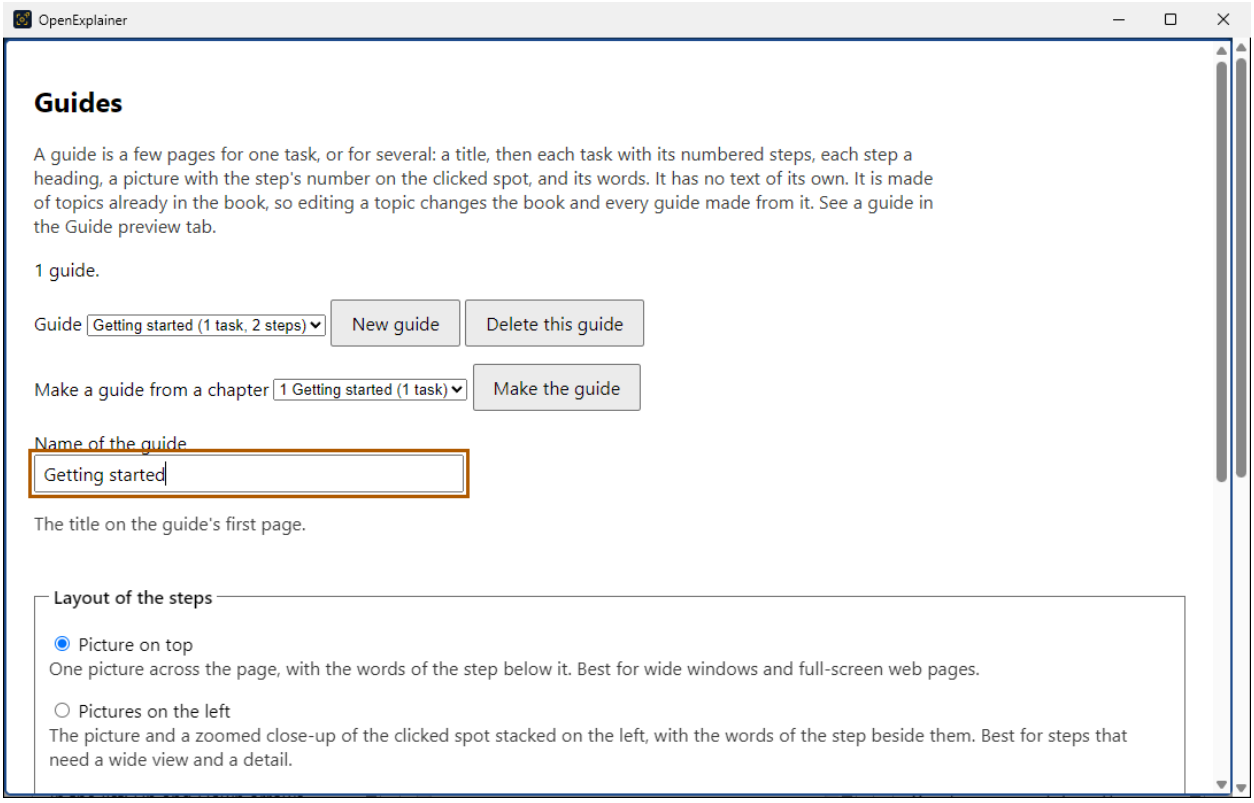
2. Click **Make the guide**, after choosing a chapter in the list called *Make a guide from a chapter*.



A. Make the guide: Makes a guide from the chapter chosen in the list.

Result: The chapter's topics that have numbered steps become the guide's tasks, and the chapter's name becomes the guide's name.

3. Change the name, the layout and the tasks if you want to, and click Save.



What a guide takes from the book

From each task a guide takes the numbered steps, with their pictures and result lines, and the boxed notes, in page order. The paragraphs, headings and loose pictures stay in the book. Each step is a heading (*Step 3*), its picture, its words and its result line.

Each step picture has the **step's number** drawn beside the clicked spot (just above it and to its left, so that the spot and the button's label stay readable), and a **close-up** of the click beside it. The click circle and the zoom size follow the *Quick guide* settings (Chapter 4). A guide can turn the close-ups off.

The two layouts

Picture on top puts the picture across the page, the close-up under it, and the words below. **Pictures on the left** stacks the picture and its close-up on the left, with the words beside them. You choose one for the whole guide and can change it for any step.

Seeing and exporting a guide

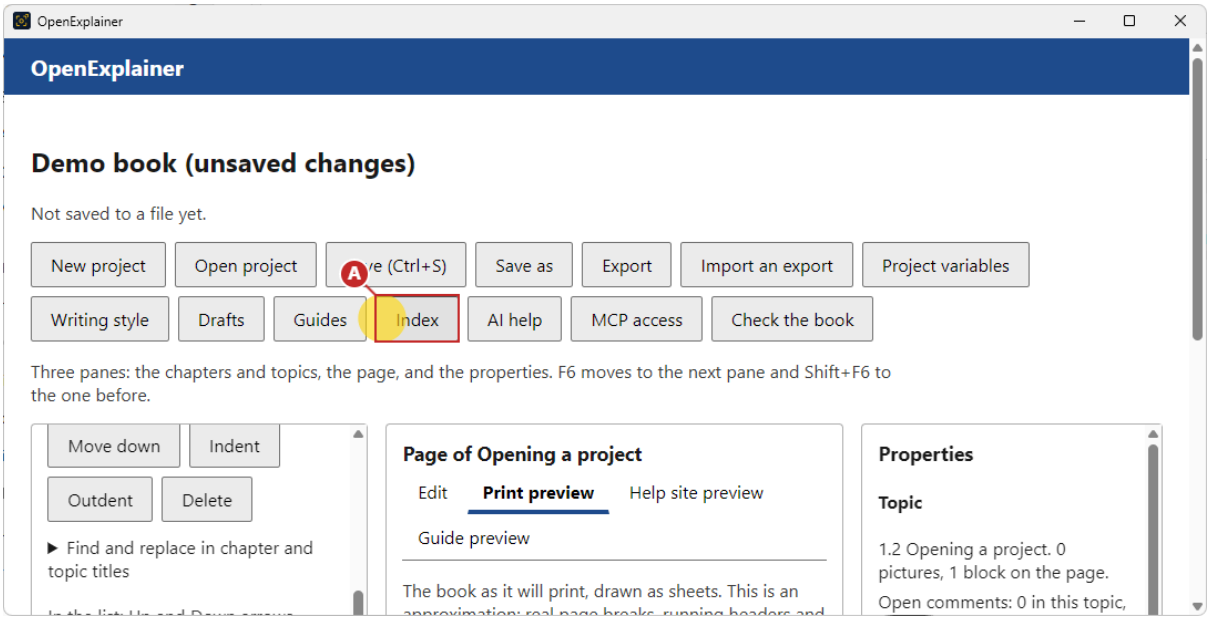
The **Guide preview** tab shows one guide, chosen from a list. To make a file, choose **Guide (Word)** or **Guide (PDF)** in the Export window and pick the guide. The guide has no cover, no contents and no chapters: its name is at the top, and each task after the first starts a new page.

> **POWER TIP**
> A picture with no description of its own uses the words of its step as its description in a guide, so every picture in a guide has one.

7.7 The index

OpenExplainer writes the **first pass** of the index for you, from the book itself, and you edit it. It needs no AI.

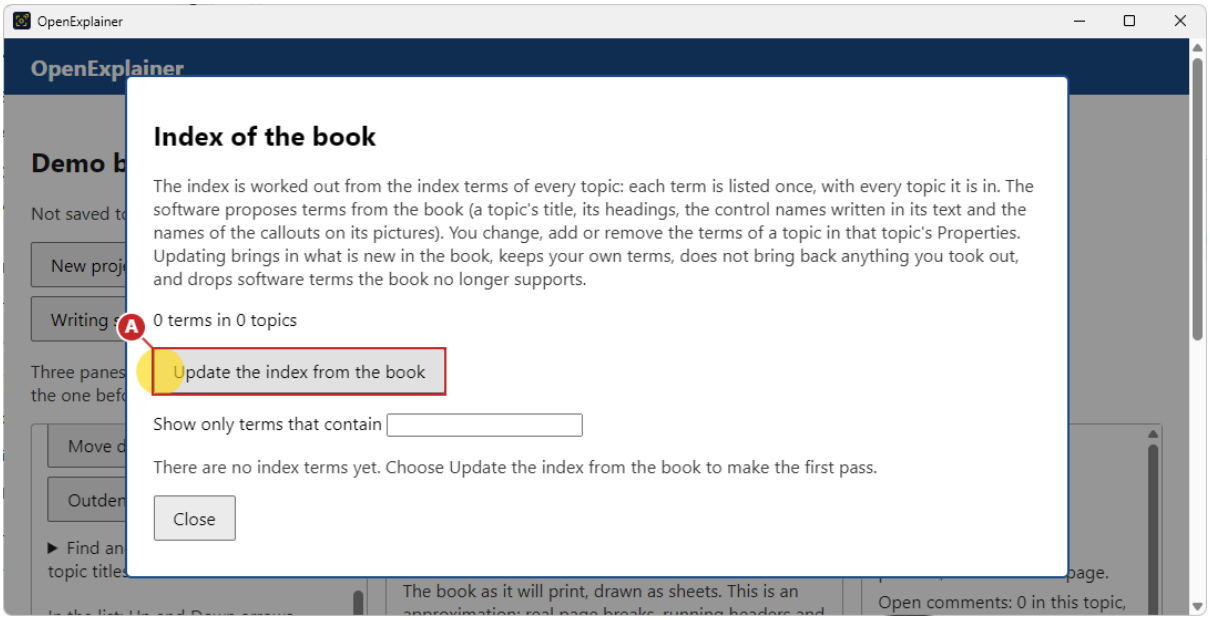
1. Click **Index**.



A. Index: Opens the index of the whole book.

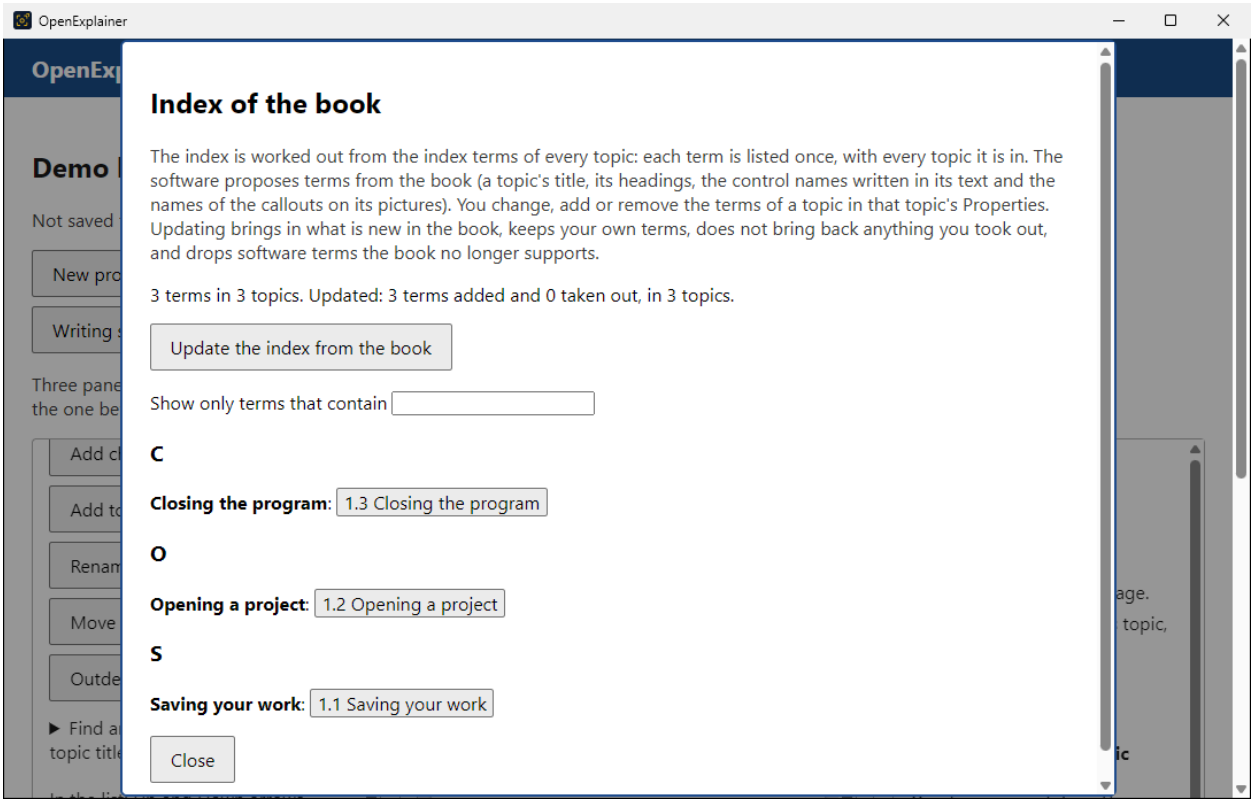
Result: A window called Index of the book opens.

2. Click **Update the index from the book**.



A. Update the index from the book: Makes the first pass of the index from the titles, headings, control names and callouts.

Result: The window says how many terms it added and took out, and lists the terms under a heading for each letter.



The first pass takes each topic's title, every control name written in double square brackets, and the names of the callouts on the pictures on its page. Headings are not terms, because a sub-heading is rarely something a reader looks up. Each term is listed once, and under it is a button for every topic it is in, which goes to that topic. A box above the list filters the terms.

Editing the terms

The terms belong to topics. To change them, select a topic and look in **Properties**, on the right. The box **Index terms, one on each line** holds that topic's terms. Change, add or remove any line. **Suggest terms** brings in new ones from the book without bringing back one you took out.

Update the index from the book keeps your own terms, does not bring back a term you removed, keeps the software's terms that the book still supports and drops the ones it does not.

Where the index appears

The index is in every output made for reading. In the PDF it is at the end of the book and is the last entry in the contents, and each term has the **page numbers** of its topics. In Word it has an Index heading with a heading for each letter. The help site has an Index page, and Markdown has an Index list. A book with no terms has no index.

CHAPTER 8

Using AI help

In This Chapter

- What AI help is and is not
- Turning on the built-in model
- Drafts you review
- Writing style notes

AI help in OpenExplainer is **optional**. Everything in this guide works by hand with no AI, and the book you make is the same either way. This chapter explains what the AI can do for you if you turn it on, and what it is never allowed to do.

8.1 What AI help is and is not

AI help writes **drafts**: first versions of short pieces of text that you then read, change and accept, or throw away. It does not write your book, and nothing it writes goes into the book until you accept it.

What it can draft

A **name and a sentence** for each callout on a picture. A **chapter opener**, which is two or three sentences at the start of a chapter. A **chapter summary** for a topic such as Summary. And **suggested boxed notes**: up to three sentences that a reader could easily miss, each with a short boxed note written from it.

A numbered procedure from a click-by-click capture (Chapter 4) is written by the program itself from what you clicked, with no AI at all.

What it is shown

The model is given only **words**: the clicked item's name, kind and description, the text of your own topics, and your writing-style notes. It is never given a picture, anything you typed in another program, or the contents of a password box. Those are never kept in a project in the first place.

Where it runs

The built-in model runs on **your PC**. It needs no account and, once it has been downloaded, no internet. The program that runs it is told to listen on your PC only, so nothing you write or capture leaves it.

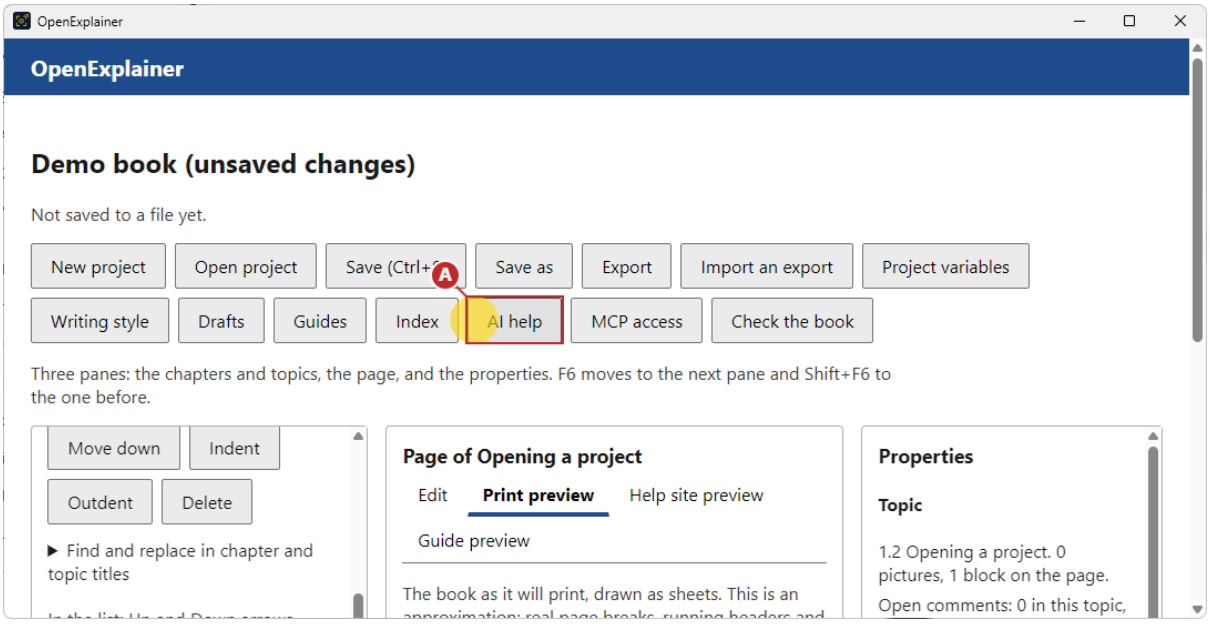
The dialog also shows a third choice, **My own key** (ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini). It is switched off and says that it is not built yet.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> A draft can be wrong. It can describe how to do a step when it should only name the task, or turn a step into a rule. The program checks what it can, for example that a drafted callout rests on something real, but you are the author. Read every draft before you accept it.

8.2 Turning on the built-in model

The built-in model is **Qwen 3.5** with 4 billion parameters, a small language model from Alibaba Cloud that has been squeezed into a smaller file so that it runs on an ordinary PC. It is about 2.7 GB, so it is not inside the installer: it is downloaded the first time you turn it on, and kept on your PC, outside your projects.

1. Click **AI help**.



A. AI help: Opens the window where you choose whether an AI drafts text, and where you get the built-in model ready.

   Result: A window called AI help opens. Under *Who drafts*, the choice is *No AI*, which is how OpenExplainer starts.

2. Choose **Built-in model on this PC**.

   Result: The window shows the model's name, its size, where it comes from, its licence, and whether it is on this PC. It also says how much free disk space and memory the PC has.

3. Click **Download the model**.

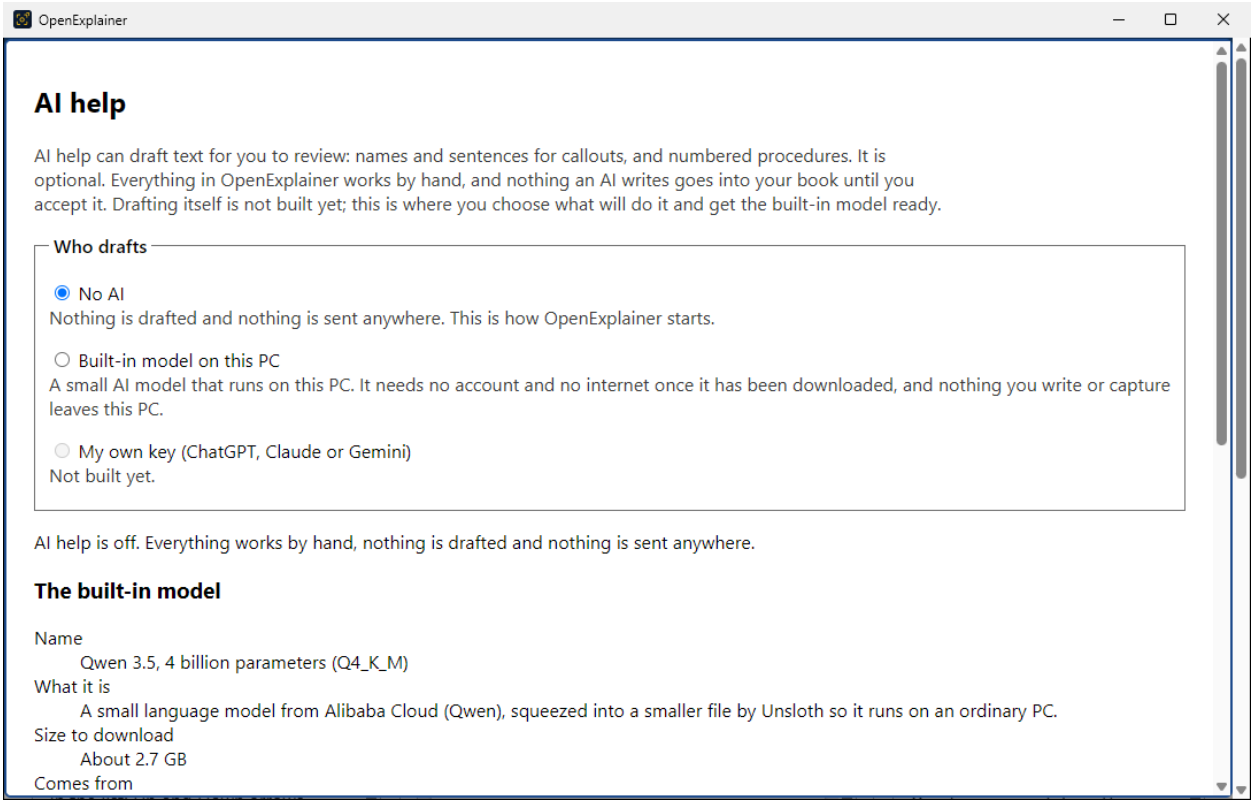
   Result: A progress bar shows the numbers in words, such as *1.2 GB of 2.7 GB*.

4. When the download has finished, click **Test the AI**.

   Result: The model writes one short sentence, so that you can see that it works. The first time can take half a minute while the model loads.

5. Click **Save**.

   Result: Your choice is kept. It is not part of any project.



Pause, resume and cancel

Pause keeps what has arrived, and **Resume** carries on from where it stopped. A dropped connection, or closing the program, also continues from where it stopped when you come back. **Cancel and delete the partial download** throws away what has arrived.

When the file is complete, the program checks it against a fixed fingerprint (a SHA-256 value). It then says *Ready*, or that the file is damaged and must be downloaded again. **Check the file** repeats that check. **Delete the model** removes the file and frees the space. **Show the licence text** shows the model's licence, which is Apache 2.0.

Good to know

The program that runs the model keeps going for about 25 seconds after OpenExplainer closes, and holds about 2 GB of memory until it stops by itself. Nothing is harmed.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> The model is a 2.7 GB download. Check the free disk space that the window reports before you start.

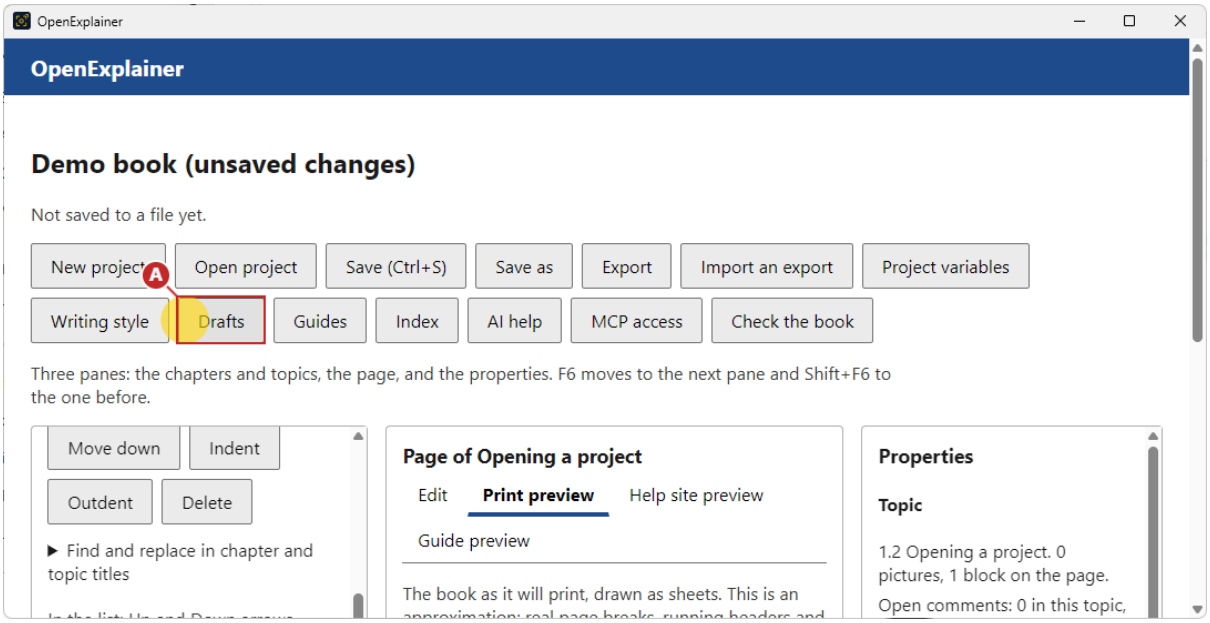
8.3 Drafts you review

A draft is never put straight into your book. It waits in the **Drafts** list, with a note in words that it is a draft and who made it, until you decide.

1. Ask for a draft with one of the buttons: **Draft callout text** (on a picture that has callouts, or for the selected topic), **Draft an opener for this chapter**, **Draft a chapter summary here** or **Suggest boxed notes for this topic**.

   Result: The model needs a moment. The draft appears in the list.

2. Click **Drafts**.



A. Drafts: Opens the list of drafts that are waiting for you to accept or reject them.

   Result: A window lists the drafts that are waiting, with the count on the button, such as *Drafts (2 waiting)*.

3. For each draft, read it, change it if you want to, and click **Accept** or **Reject**.

   Result: Accept puts the words where they belong. Reject throws the draft away.

What you see for each draft

Each draft says where it is and who made it. A callout sentence shows the sentence now and an editable draft, and a fold-out shows exactly what the AI was given. A procedure shows each step in its own box with its picture number and what it was made from, and a flag on a step with no

name. An opener or a summary shows where it will go and its words in a box that you can edit. Suggested boxed notes show the sentence they rest on beside the note, so you can compare them.

Go to the picture (or topic) takes you to what the draft is about. Use Tab to move through the entries and Enter on a button. After Accept or Reject the keyboard moves to the next entry, and Escape closes the list.

What the program checks

The AI is asked for an answer in a fixed shape. An answer that does not fit is thrown away with a plain message. It is never half-used. A drafted step may only name controls that were in your capture, and an unclear label becomes *needs a name* instead of a guess. A drafted opener or summary that is a list, has quotation marks, names something that is not in the chapter, or says *you will learn* is thrown away and tried once more.

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> Drafts are in no preview and in no export. A draft you never accepted cannot reach a reader.

8.4 Writing style notes

The **Writing style** window has a box called **Notes** for the AI. Say in your own words how the book should read. The AI reads your notes before it writes a draft.

1. Click **Writing style**.
2. Type your notes in the **Notes** box. The box holds up to 2,000 letters, and it says how many you have used.
3. Click **Save**.

Good notes are short and concrete. For example: *Speak to the reader as you. Say click for buttons and choose for menu items. Keep sentences short.* You can also say which words to use for which things.

The notes are saved with the project, so a colleague who opens it gets the same style. Leave the box empty if you have no notes. With AI help off, the Notes box does nothing.

The second box in the same window, **Words to avoid**, is a plain list, not an instruction to the AI, and it works with AI help off (topic 6.2).

CHAPTER 9

Letting an assistant do the work

In This Chapter

- Turning on MCP access
- Connecting an assistant
- What an assistant can and cannot do

MCP, the Model Context Protocol, is the way an AI assistant such as Claude uses a program's tools. With MCP turned on, an assistant can document a program **while nobody is at the keyboard**: it makes a project, takes pictures of windows and clicks, writes the pages, names the callouts, builds the index, runs the book check and makes any export.

This is optional, and it is **off** until you turn it on. This guide was itself made that way: an assistant used these tools, working inside one folder, to write the text and take every picture.

9.1 Turning on MCP access

MCP access has three settings: whether it is on, which **folder** an assistant may use, and whether it may capture a **whole screen**.

1. Click **MCP access**.

   Result: A window called MCP access opens. Every setting starts off.

2. Tick **Turn on MCP access**.

3. Type the **Folder an assistant may use**, or click **Choose the folder**.

   Result: An assistant can only open, save and export inside this folder, and nowhere else on this PC. OpenExplainer will not turn MCP on until you have chosen a folder that exists.

4. Leave **Let an assistant capture a whole screen, not only one window** unticked, unless you need it.

5. Click **Save**.

The settings are kept in a small file called mcp.json in OpenExplainer's settings folder (see topic 10.2). They are read each time an assistant connects, so a change takes effect for the next assistant that connects.

The folder and the log

Every use of a tool is written to a plain file called **OpenExplainer MCP log.txt** in the folder. It says when, which tool, whether it was OK or REFUSED, and the first line of the answer. What was written on a page is not in the log.

Whole screens

With whole-screen capture off, an assistant takes **one window at a time**, and a click capture keeps only the clicks inside the window it was told to watch. A mail window or a password manager on the same screen never gets into a project.

> ⚠ **CAUTION**
> If you turn whole-screen capture on, anything on your screen can end up in a picture. Close private windows first, and look at every picture afterwards.

9.2 Connecting an assistant

An assistant has to be told how to start OpenExplainer. The MCP access window gives you the lines to copy, once, for each assistant. You only need to do this once per assistant.

Claude Desktop

In the MCP access window, click **Copy these settings**, and add them to Claude Desktop's settings file, claude_desktop_config.json. They name the program and the word --mcp. The block looks like this, with the path of your own openexplainer.exe: { "mcpServers": { "openexplainer": { "command": "the path of openexplainer.exe", "args": ["--mcp"] } } }

Claude Code

Click **Copy this command** and run it once in a terminal. It is *claude mcp add openexplainer*, then two dashes, then the path of openexplainer.exe in quotation marks, then --mcp.

What happens when it connects

The assistant starts OpenExplainer with the word **--mcp**. The program then runs with a window that nobody can see and that is not in the taskbar. The assistant talks to it by standard input and output, one line at a time. When the assistant disconnects, the program ends. If MCP is off, the assistant is refused when it connects, with the words that say how to turn it on.

An assistant works in its own hidden copy of OpenExplainer. **Do not edit the same project in the window while an assistant is working on it.** Each change is saved as it is made, so the last one to save would overwrite the other's work.

> ⚠ **CAUTION**
> While an assistant is working, either keep the project closed in the window or work in a different project. Two things changing one file at once is the one way to lose work.

9.3 What an assistant can and cannot do

An assistant has tools in five groups. Every tool checks everything first, so one that cannot be done says why in plain words and changes nothing.

The tools

Projects: list, create, open and save projects. **Reading**: get the outline, get a topic (its page, its pictures with what was clicked, its callouts and index terms), check the book and list the guides. **Writing**: add, change and delete topics, write a page or add blocks to it, describe a picture and name its callouts, make a callout from a click, set the variables and the index terms, update the index, create, change and delete a guide, choose which part of a picture is shown, and set the book's settings (the zoom, the automatic zoom for print, the click circles, the writing style and the words to avoid).

Capture: list the open windows (a Save or Open window of the program being documented is listed too), capture one window, capture a rectangle (only when whole screens are allowed), start, check and stop a click capture, look at a picture, and remove one. **Exports**: make a help site, JSON, Markdown, Word, PDF or a guide as Word or PDF.

A page is written as blocks: a heading, a paragraph, a picture, a numbered procedure or a callout box. Text uses the same marks as the editor: two stars for bold, one star for italic and double square brackets for a control name.

What it does when it captures

The assistant does the clicking in the program with its own tools. OpenExplainer watches and records, exactly as it does for a person: a picture from just before each click, and a note of what was clicked. It never records anything typed and never a password box's contents. Each kept picture has its click note and a first callout at the item that was clicked.

To say what was clicked, OpenExplainer asks Windows what is under the pointer. The window under the pointer is got ready as the pointer first moves over it, so even the first click in a program built on a web browser engine is usually named, and a click on the label of a button is named after the button. If another program's see-through window is in the way, the window that was really clicked is asked instead.

The small **Stop** window (during a click capture) and the **Cancel** window (during any other capture) are always visible, so a person who comes back can stop it at once. A copy of OpenExplainer does not capture its own windows.

What it cannot do yet

It does not click or type in the program being documented. The assistant has to do that with its own tools. It does not use the built-in AI to draft text: the assistant writes the text itself. It works on one project at a time for each connection.

Some things can only be done in the program's window: moving or resizing a callout's outline, drawing marks on a picture, and choosing one picture's own click circle. An assistant can name a callout and describe it. A click that landed on the window itself gives a small box round the click with no name, and its place can be changed by hand in the Callouts window (topic 5.2).

> ✳ **BRIGHT IDEA**
>
> Ask an assistant to describe every picture and every callout as it goes. It can see each picture through the tools, and a description written while the picture is fresh is better than one written at the end.

CHAPTER 10

Reference

In This Chapter

- Using the keyboard
- Where your files are kept
- When something goes wrong
- Glossary

Short answers to the questions that come up while you use OpenExplainer: the keyboard, where things are kept, what to do when something does not work, and what the words mean.

10.1 Using the keyboard

OpenExplainer is meant to be fully usable with the keyboard alone and with a screen reader. Every button can be reached with Tab, and every window closes with the keyboard.

Everywhere

Tab and **Shift+Tab** move between controls. **Enter** or **Space** presses a button. **Ctrl+S** saves the project. **F6** moves to the next pane (chapters and topics, the page, the properties) and **Shift+F6** to the one before, and the new pane is announced. On a narrow window the panes stack, and F6 still moves between them.

In the list of chapters and topics

Up and **Down** move between items. **Right** opens a chapter and **Left** closes it. **F2** renames the selected item and **Delete** removes it, after asking. **Alt with Up or Down** moves the item, and **Alt with Right or Left** indents or outdents it.

On the page

Each block is a labelled box. A new block goes after the block the keyboard was last in, and the keyboard goes into it. Every block has **Move up**, **Move down**, **Comments** and **Delete** buttons, and a button that cannot be used is switched off. The tabs above the page (Edit, Print preview, Help site preview and Guide preview) move with **Left** and **Right**, and **Home** and **End** go to the first and the last.

In windows

Escape closes any window and keeps nothing you changed, the same as the Cancel button. Nothing is kept until you press the window's Save, OK or similar button. When a window closes, the keyboard goes back to the button that opened it.

When you point at a picture (in the Callouts, Picture view and Drawing windows), **Tab** to the outline, the marker or the region on the sample. An **arrow key** moves it by 1 pixel and **Shift with an arrow** by 10. **Control with an arrow** makes an outline wider or taller (Right or Down) or narrower or shorter (Left or Up). **Escape during a drag** puts everything back. The number boxes always hold the exact numbers.

Screen readers

The title of the window names the project and says *(unsaved changes)* in words. Status and progress are said in words, for example after a move, a delete or a save. Colour is never the only way to tell things apart: every status has a word and a symbol, every kind of callout box says its name, and a colour check says its result in words. A picture's description is read as its alternative text.

> **⚠ CAUTION**
> If you find something you cannot do with the keyboard, or that a screen reader does not say, that is a fault in OpenExplainer, not in how you use it. Please tell the author.

10.2 Where your files are kept

OpenExplainer keeps your work and its own settings in different places, so that moving or deleting one does not harm the other.

Your project

A project is **one file** named after the project, with the ending **.openexplainer**. It holds the whole book: the text, the pictures, the callouts and marks, and the settings. Keep it wherever you like, and copy it like any file. To keep a safe copy, use **Save as**.

The program

The installer puts the program in your own folder, **%LOCALAPPDATA%\OpenExplainer**. It needs no administrator rights. It adds a Start menu entry, a desktop shortcut and an entry in Windows' Apps list, where it can be uninstalled, and it tells Windows, for you only, that a file ending in .openexplainer opens in OpenExplainer.

Settings

Settings are in **%APPDATA%\org.openexplainer.app**: the AI choice (ai.json) and the MCP settings (mcp.json). They are not part of any project.

The AI model and other data

The built-in AI model, about 2.7 GB, is kept in **%LOCALAPPDATA%\org.openexplainer.app**, with the browser engine's own profile and a log of the AI program. Uninstalling the program leaves this folder alone, which is right for a big download, and the interactive uninstaller offers to delete it. **Delete the model** in the AI help window removes the model by itself.

Temporary files

While a PDF is made, a work folder called **openexplainer-pdf** is created in the PC's temporary folder. It is cleared away after each export, and any leftover is cleared the next time.

To type one of those paths, paste it into the address bar of File Explorer. For example, %APPDATA% opens your settings area.

10.3 When something goes wrong

Windows warns about the installer

The installer is not signed yet, so Windows SmartScreen may warn when you run it. Only run an installer that you got from the project's own page. Signing the installer is planned, and the warning will then go away.

The window I want is not in the list

In the Capture window, click **Refresh the list**. A window that is minimized has to be restored first, and the list says so.

A capture is taking too long

A capture is normally over in a fraction of a second. If it is not, press the **Cancel** button in the small Cancel window. The keyboard may be in the other program, which is why that window has its own button.

A click has no name

OpenExplainer keeps the name of a clicked item only for buttons, menus and similar controls, and only when Windows can say what it is. It gets a window ready the first time the pointer moves over it, so the first click in a program built on a web browser engine is usually named too. A click on the writing or the picture inside a button counts as a click on the button. And when another program's see-through window, such as a writing helper's overlay, is over the window, OpenExplainer asks the window you clicked what is there, and the click's note says so. If a click still has no name, because the item is a list item, a link or a text box (whose names are never kept), or because the pointer was moved and clicked in one go, name the callout yourself in the Callouts window.

A callout is in the wrong place or too big

When the click landed on the window itself and not on a control, the first callout is a small box round the click, with no name. Open **Callouts**, give it a name, and change the four numbers of the outline, or drag it on the sample, to put it round the real control. A project made with an earlier version of OpenExplainer may still have a callout that covers the whole window: the same steps fix it.

A picture prints too small

Choose **Picture view** and crop it, or zoom in on the click, or turn on the automatic zoom in **Zoom settings**. The print preview lists every picture that will print too small.

The contents of the PDF has no page numbers

The page numbers are read out of the finished file. If that is not possible, the contents is left without numbers, never with wrong ones, and the export says so. Make the PDF again.

An assistant is refused

MCP access is off until you turn it on. Open **MCP access**, tick **Turn on MCP access**, choose the folder, and click Save. Remember that an assistant can only work inside the folder you chose.

Draft callout text says it cannot

AI help needs the built-in model. Open **AI help**, choose **Built-in model on this PC**, and check that the model is downloaded and says *Ready*. Everything else works without it.

A project does not open when I double-click it

The installer makes the ending .openexplainer open in OpenExplainer, but Windows may keep another program for it if one was chosen before. Right-click the project's file, choose **Open with**, choose OpenExplainer, and choose to always use it. If OpenExplainer was installed by another person on the PC, it is not set up for you: use **Open project** in the program.

A project was made by a newer version

A project saved by a newer version of OpenExplainer is refused with a message that asks you to update the program. Older projects are upgraded by themselves when you open them.

10.4 Glossary

Accessibility check. An optional look at the book for things that make it harder to use, such as a picture with no description. See the book check.

Alternative text. The words that stand for a picture for a reader who cannot see it. In OpenExplainer it is the picture's description, with the words of its marks.

Book check. The optional list of things worth fixing in a book (topic 6.1).

Callout. A lettered marker on a picture, with an outline round a part and a line to the marker. Letters belong to pictures (topic 5.2).

Callout box. A boxed note on a page: a Design Tip, Caution, Bright Idea, Power Tip, Time Saver or New in this version (topic 3.4).

Chapter. A top-level part of the book. It can hold topics.

Click circle. A transparent circle drawn on the spot where a click was made. It is drawn when the book is made, not into the picture (topic 4.5).

Control name. The label of a button, menu or box, written between double square brackets so that it is shown in bold and used by the index and the book check (topic 3.5).

Description. What a picture shows, in words (topic 5.1).

Draft. A piece of text that the AI wrote and that is waiting for you to accept or reject it (topic 8.3).

Guide. A few pages for one task, made from topics already in the book (topic 7.6).

Help site. The book as a folder of web pages with search (topic 7.4).

Index. A list of terms with the topics they are in (topic 7.7).

MCP. The Model Context Protocol, the way an AI assistant uses a program's tools (Chapter 9).

Marks. Arrows, text boxes, rectangles and numbered markers drawn over a picture (topic 5.4).

Picture view. Which part of a picture is shown: the whole, a region, or a zoom on the click (topic 5.3).

Procedure. A numbered list of steps. The numbers follow the order, and each procedure starts at 1 (topic 3.3).

Project. One file with the ending .openexplainer that holds the whole book.

Status. Where a topic is in its life: Not started, Captured, Drafted, Reviewed or Needs recheck (topic 3.7).

Topic. A part of a chapter, with a page of its own. A topic can hold more topics.

Variable. A name in double curly brackets that stands for a value kept once for the whole book, such as PRODUCT (topic 3.6).

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